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Collated September 2026

Protecting the rights of farmed animals

The Animal Justice Party Aotearoa New Zealand (AJP) asserts that all forms of animal farming are ethically indefensible, fundamentally unjust, and must end. Every animal, regardless of the product they are exploited for, has the inherent right to live free from suffering, exploitation, and commodification. AJP is committed to driving a rapid transition to a plant-based economy, recognising the urgent need to dismantle systems that cause the greatest harm to animals. While working towards the complete abolition of animal farming, we demand immediate reforms to eliminate the most severe suffering and uphold the dignity and rights of all sentient beings.

In alignment with Te Tiriti o Waitangi principles, AJP affirms that protecting the rights of animals requires genuine partnership with Māori. We honour the unique relationship between tangata whenua and the natural world and commit to ensuring that policy development and implementation incorporates Māori perspectives and knowledge systems. Concepts such as kaitiakitanga (guardianship), mauri (life force), and whakapapa (ancestral connection) offer powerful frameworks that challenge extractive models of agriculture and envision a future grounded in respect, care and justice for all living beings.

Abolish all farming of animals

The Animal Justice Party Aotearoa NZ (AJP) advocates for the complete abolition of animal farming. All animals used in farming, regardless of the intended product or purpose, have an equal right to live free from suffering, exploitation and neglect. AJP supports a transition to system that respects animal rights, protects the environment and promotes public health through plant-based, cellular and sustainable agriculture.

The industrial farming of animals represents the largest source of animal exploitation and cruelty globally. Every year in New Zealand, billions of animals, including fish, are bred, confined and/or killed for food production. This includes, for example: 119.5 million chickens, broiler chickens, (2022),[1] 4.67 million dairy cows (2023/24)[2] and approximately 72.7 million farmed fish and shellfish individuals (noting this is an estimate as fish are not measured by number of individuals but by metric weight alone, the stated figure of 109, 016 metric tonnes[3] is equivalent to the weight of approximately 72,677 cars).

These animals endure significant physical and psychological suffering throughout their abbreviated lives, treated as mere units of production. AJP recognises that these animals are sentient, and have interests in living lives free from suffering, with autonomy, and the freedom to express their natural behaviors. These interests are often comparable to the similar interests of humans, and establish the legal personhood of sentient animals, along with rights which must be protected in the law. These rights are fundamentally incompatible with ownership or consumptive practices.

All forms of farming impose severe harms and infringe on the rights of animals. The dairy industry, central to New Zealand's economy, subjects cows to annual pregnancies, separation from their calves, and intensive milking that leads to painful conditions like mastitis. Male calves, considered "surplus" to the industry, are typically killed within days of birth. Chickens raised for meat (broilers) are genetically manipulated to grow at unnatural rates, leading to painful skeletal disorders, while hens in the egg industry are confined in crowded conditions and killed when their productivity declines. Male chicks are killed by maceration within their first few days.

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[1] https://www.helgilibrary.com/indicators/meat-chicken-producing-animals-slaughtered/new-zealand/
[2] https://www.lic.co.nz/news/stable-dairy-production-continues-nz-dairy-stats/
[3] https://www.ceicdata.com/en/new-zealand/agricultural-production-and-consumption/nz-aquaculture-production

The fashion and textile industries also represent significant sources of animal exploitation. In New Zealand, the wool industry alone involves approximately 25.3 million sheep (2022)[4], while possum fur and leather production contribute to animal suffering and death.

All farming operations, whether animals are raised for meat, milk, wool, leather, down, or any other product, including emerging industries such as insect and eel farming, prioritise profit over the welfare of sentient animals and infringe on their rights. While different forms of farming vary in the severity of their cruelty, all animal farming fundamentally denies animals their personhood, along with their rights to autonomy and freedom from exploitation.

AJP also recognises that animal farming imposes an unsustainable burden on natural ecosystems both in Aotearoa and globally. The environmental impact of animal agriculture is far-reaching and deeply harmful. It is a major driver of greenhouse gas emissions, particularly methane and nitrous oxide, which are far more potent than carbon dioxide in terms of warming potential. Animal farming also requires vast amounts of land for grazing and feed production, leading to deforestation and habitat destruction that endanger native species and contribute to biodiversity loss. In New Zealand, intensive dairying has been directly linked to the degradation of waterways, with nutrient runoff and effluent polluting rivers and lakes, harming aquatic life and undermining the health of entire ecosystems. Leather tanning creates toxic pollution and wool farming contributes to land degradation and water pollution. Globally, the conversion of forests to pasture and feed crops is one of the leading causes of biodiversity collapse and a significant barrier to achieving climate goals. Transitioning away from animal farming is therefore essential not only to reduce animal suffering but to restore ecological balance and safeguard the planet's capacity to support life.

Furthermore, intensive animal farming presents a critical threat to global public health by creating ideal conditions for the emergence of zoonotic diseases. This risk arises through two major pathways. Firstly, the confinement of animals in overcrowded and often unhygienic environments facilities the transmission and mutation of pathogens that can jump from animals to humans. These facilities can act as breeding grounds for new viral and bacterial strains, with the close contact between animals and workers increasing transmission risks. Secondly, the routine use of antibiotics in animal agriculture, often used preventatively due to unsanitary conditions and to promote rapid

[4] https://www.stats.govt.nz/news/fewer-sheep-and-dairy-cattle-in-2022/

growth, is fuelling the global crisis of antibiotic resistance. This overuse contributes to the emergence of 'superbugs' - bacteria that are resistant to multiple antibiotics. The World Health Organisation has identified identified antimicrobial resistance as one of the top ten global public health threats facing humanity, warning that without urgent action, we could enter a 'post-antibiotic era' where common infections and minor injuries may once again become fatal.[5]

AJP affirms Te Tiriti o Waitangi as a foundational document and recognises the importance of working in partnership with tangata whenua in the pursuit of justice for animals and collective, intergenerational wellbeing. This includes supporting Māori-led exploration of how *kaitiakitanga* can guide non-exploitative relationships with animals. Māori frameworks such as *kaitiakitanga*, *mauri*, and *wairua* offer perspectives that challenge dominant colonial-industrial relationships with animals.

We acknowledge the importance of Māori-led conversations around the future of food systems, species protection and animal rights and that some traditional harvesting practices form part of Māori identity and whakapapa. While AJP opposes all animal use and advocates for a post-exploitative food system, we are committed to respectful, Treaty-consistent dialogue with hapū and iwi.

In order to protect the rights of animals and dismantle exploitative industries, AJP advocates for a systematic transition away from all forms of animal farming, including for food, fibre and fashion, towards plant-based, cellular and sustainable alternatives. This transition will eliminate the use of animals as commodities, dramatically reduce environmental destruction, and promote public health. It must be managed carefully to support farmers, rural communities, and affected industries through inclusive and just transition strategies.

Key Objectives:

1. Establish a clear timeline for phasing out all forms of animal farming, with specific targets for each industry sector.
2. Provide economic and technical support for farmers to transition to other industries.
   See AJP's Plant-Based Transition policies for further objectives aligned with this transition, including focusing on investment in plant-based and cellular agriculture

[5] https://www.who.int/news-room/fact-sheets/detail/antimicrobial-resistance

research and development and creation of comprehensive transition programmes to support farmers in converting to plant-based agriculture or other sustainable enterprises.

3. Prohibit the expansion, or the establishment, of animal farming operations.
4. Prohibit all forms of intensive animal farming.
5. Legislate transparency in all animal farming operations through increased monitoring and enforcement and public reporting. See Regulatory Oversight and Enforcement Policy.
6. Introduce consistent legislation that defines and acknowledges animal sentience, ensuring legal protection from harm. See Legislative Foundations Policy.
7. Expand the application of the Animal Welfare Act 1999 to all species of any order for which there is strong evidence of sentience in at least one species of that order, following Birch et al. (2021)'s framework.[6] See Legislative Foundations Policy.
8. Require greater legislative protection of animal welfare. See Reducing Harm and Mistreatment and Legislative Foundations Policies.
9. Work with Māori leaders, ethicists and communities to explore Treaty-grounded, culturally inclusive pathways for protecting animal wellbeing.

The Animal Justice Party Aotearoa NZ (AJP) affirms that all animals used in farming, whether for food, fibre, or fashion, possess inherent personhood, dignity and rights. These policies apply equally to all farmed animals, land-based or aquatic, regardless of the product or industry they are exploited for. Our interim policies seek to reduce harm while working toward a future where no animal is treated as a commodity or object of human use.

May 2025

6 https://www.lse.ac.uk/business/consulting/assets/documents/Sentience-in-Cephalopod-Molluscs-and-Decapod-Crustaceans-Final-Report-November-2021.pdf

Independent Animal Welfare Governance to Reduce Harm

The Animal Justice Party (AJP) envisions a New Zealand where compassion, sustainability and ethical practices guide our treatment of animals. While we advocate for a complete transition to a plant-based farming system, we recognise that meaningful societal changes require time and a 'Just Transition'.[7] In the interim, we are committed to reducing the most severe harm and mistreatment of animals by improving oversight of farming practices and strengthening legislation to provide stronger protections and ensure higher welfare standards for all animals in Aotearoa.

New Zealand's animal welfare system must be free from conflicts of interest and bias. Currently, the role of Minister for Animal Welfare is embedded within the Ministry for Primary Industries (MPI), an institution heavily tied to the animal agriculture sector. To address this, AJP calls for the establishment of an independent Commissioner for Animals.[8] This role would ensure impartial oversight and monitoring of animal welfare and protection in Aotearoa New Zealand and more effective enforcement of, and compliance with, the Animal Welfare Act 1999. See Regulatory Oversight and Enforcement Policy.

The Animal Welfare Act 1999 outlines several needs (known as the "Five Freedoms") which must be provided for farmed animals:

- Proper and sufficient food and water.
- Adequate shelter.
- The opportunity to display normal patterns of behaviour.
- Physical handling in a manner which minimises the likelihood of unreasonable or unnecessary pain or distress.
- Protection from, and rapid diagnosis of, any significant injury or disease.

While the Five Freedoms are insufficient to protect all the rights that sentient animals are entitled to (such as the right to life), they represent the minimum legislative standards to be adhered to. However, current farming methods and the codes of welfare frequently do not meet these standards, especially in intensive animal farming. Additionally, there is limited action or motivation from Government decision makers or regulators to initiate and drive positive welfare law reform[9] to align current farming

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[7] https://www.mbie.govt.nz/business-and-employment/economic-growth/previous-economic-development-work/just-transition/just-transitions-guide/foundations/what-are-just-transitions

[8] See AJP policy Commissioner for animals

[9] A scientific network entitled 'Laying the foundations for positive animal welfare' has been established to advance its scientific understanding (https://LIFTanimalwelfare.eu/). This network comprises more than 330 scientists from 42 countries. The resulting definition is "Positive animal welfare is defined as the

practices with the Five Freedoms.[10] AJP would therefore implement, as interim measures, regulations to ensure that the Five Freedoms are met in animal agriculture.

Emerging technologies, including artificial intelligence, are increasingly being used in animal agriculture to monitor, manage or even conceal harmful practices. Without ethical oversight and transparency, these tools risk entrenching cruelty and further distancing the public from the realities of animal exploitation. AJP supports legislation to ensure that any technological use involving animals prioritises their welfare and does not enable or obscure mistreatment.

Key Objectives

1. Establish a Commissioner for Animals, see Regulatory Oversight and Enforcement policy.
2. Abolish the classification of animals as property and introduce consistent legislation that defines and acknowledges animal sentience, ensuring legal protection from harm. See Legislation and Regulation Reform Policy.
3. Prohibit the use of artificial intelligence and emerging technologies that enable or conceal animal cruelty, and legislate for transparency, ethical oversight and welfare-first design in all AI applications involving animals.

May 2025

animal flourishing through the experience of predominantly positive mental states and the development of competence and resilience" https://royalsocietypublishing.org/doi/epdf/10.1098/rsbl.2024.0382.

[10] https://ourarchive.otago.ac.nz/esploro/outputs/report/Animal-Welfare-in-New-Zealand-Oversight/9926479549501891/filesAndLinks?index=0

Ensuring Humane Transport Conditions

The Animal Justice Party (AJP) envisions a New Zealand where compassion, sustainability and ethical practices guide our treatment of animals. While we ultimately seek a complete transition away from animal agriculture towards plant-based and cellular systems, we recognise the urgent need to reduce the suffering of animals who are currently trapped in this system. One of the most severe and widespread breaches of the five freedoms[11] occurs during transport, particularly when animals are moved between farms, saleyards and slaughterhouses.

Every year, millions of animals in New Zealand endure long and stressful journeys that cause significant physical and psychological distress. The process of transport exposes animals to unfamiliar environments, loud noises, rough handling, overcrowding and prolonged confinement, often without adequate rest, food or water. Vulnerable groups such as bobby calves and dairy cows are especially at risk. Despite existing regulations, the current system prioritises cost-efficiency over animal wellbeing, with inadequate limits on journey length, stocking density and handling standards.

Live export is one of the most extreme examples of suffering associated with transport. Although New Zealand banned the export of livestock by sea for slaughter in 2023, this ban is under threat from Government proposals in 2025 to overturn it, a move AJP strongly opposes, see AJP Live Export policy. Furthermore, other forms of live export continue, including the export of farmed species like eels by air, which also subjects animals to prolonged and distressing journeys.

Transport regulations must be equally stringent for animals farmed for non-food products, including alpacas, angora rabbits and other fibre-producing animals. These animals often face similar or greater transport risks due to less established welfare protocols and monitoring systems.

AJP calls for a complete overhaul of animal transport regulations to recognise the specific needs of each species, regardless of their intended use. While animal farming continues, we demand far stricter controls on journey times, space allowances, rest periods and handling practices, as well as the retention and strengthening of the live export ban. Our long-term vision remains the complete replacement of animal farming

[11] https://www.animalhumanesociety.org/health/five-freedoms-animals

with ethical, sustainable alternatives, but until that is achieved, animals must be afforded the highest possible level of protection.

Key Objectives:

1. Implement comprehensive reforms to strengthen the Animal Welfare (Transport within New Zealand) Code of Welfare.
2. Establish stricter maximum journey times aligned with New Zealand's geographic and agricultural context, particularly for vulnerable animals like bobby calves.
3. Extend the current ban on live export by sea to include all live animal exports, including by air (noting the need for some exceptions, such as companion animals migrating with their guardians).

May 2025

Extending the Live Export Ban

Animal Justice Party Aotearoa New Zealand (AJP) will campaign to prevent the ban on sending steers, heifers, cows and bulls (**'cattle'**) and sheep, deer and goats by sea from being repealed.

AJP will also campaign for an end to exporting live animals by air, except in the case of companion animals relocating overseas and coming into New Zealand with their families, zoo animals and horses requiring relocation. Refer to AJP's Policy regarding Horse Racing.

The Animal Welfare Act 1999 was amended in 2022 to state that after 30 April 2023 no livestock may be exported from New Zealand by sea.[12] Federated Farmers, ACT Party[13] and National Party[14] have all made public statements in support of repealing this amendment.

Although it is not well known, we also export millions of animals every year by air, namely, goats, llamas, pigs, alpacas, bees, deer, horses, cats, dogs and day-old baby chicks. In 2022 more than 2000 goats and 3.4 million day-old chicks were sent offshore by plane. We also export aquatic species such as longfin eels even though they are 'at risk' native animals[15] and crayfish.[16]

Further, regardless of the method of transport, once the animals are exported, New Zealand no longer has any control over how our animals are treated in the destination country. For example, boiling crayfish alive in a restaurant is an offence in New Zealand but similar rules do not necessarily apply overseas.[17]

Key Principles:

1. AJP will campaign to keep the current ban on livestock export by sea

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[12] https://www.mpi.govt.nz/export/animals/live-animals-including-livestock/requirement-documents-for-exporting-live-animals/animal-welfare-export-certificates/live-sheep-and-cattle-exports/

[13] https://www.farmersweekly.co.nz/politics/feds-backs-move-to-repeal-live-exports-ban/

[14] https://www.google.com/url?q=https://assets.nationbuilder.com/nationalparty/pages/17747/attachments/original/1681852968/Getting_Back_to_Farming.pdf?1681852968&sa=D&source=docs&ust=1693736017952896&usg=AOvVaw0qT3lbl46pRahbnkZovPdN

[15] https://www.newsroom.co.nz/at-risk-and-on-the-menu

[16] https://safe.org.nz/our-work/animals-in-aotearoa/live-export-trade

[17] https://www.legislation.govt.nz/regulation/public/2018/0050/23.0/LMS22832.html

2. AJP will campaign to ban all live export of animals by air that will not have all physical, health, and behavioural needs met, during travel or at destination, as defined in Section 4 of the Animal Welfare Act 1999[18]

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[18] New Zealand Veterinary Association| Policy|Ratified: Nov2019

Key issues with live export by sea:

1. The conditions on board are not up to New Zealand Code of Welfare Standards.
2. The standard only provides 1.67 square metres per 400 kg cow.[19]
3. Conditions on board result in a number of deaths due to infection and heat stress. Comparing mortality on board[20] with cattle living on land, as many industry supporters have, underestimates the overall suffering (morbidity) of the cattle on board, many of whom are also pregnant.
4. There is no requirement that the animals in the destination country are treated according to New Zealand standards.
5. Most of the cows exported went to China. World Animal Protection has assessed Chinese laws in areas preventing animal suffering, protecting animals used in farming and government accountability for animal welfare, as having one of the very lowest scores in the world.[21]
6. Animals from New Zealand have been selected for the New Zealand environment and are not adapted to conditions in overseas farms. e.g. the Holstein Friesian breed of cow that New Zealand sent to China originated in Scotland.[22]

Key issues with live export by air:

1. 3.4 million day-old chicks are sent overseas each year. While colony cages are still legal in New Zealand, some of the exported chickens will live in cages that have been outlawed in New Zealand. Many will be slaughtered without stunning, which is illegal in New Zealand.[23]
2. Aside from horses, the Ministry for Primary Industries does not require official oversight of animals during flight to ensure they are protected from potential injury and death.
3. There is no requirement that the animals in the destination

19 https://www.mpi.govt.nz/dmsdocument/911/direct

20 https://www.mpi.govt.nz/export/animals/live-animal-and-germplasm-export-statistics-and-reports/

21 https://api.worldanimalprotection.org/compare

22 https://www.globaltimes.cn/page/202301/1284569.shtml

23 https://www.ciwf.org.uk/media/5235309/Welfare-sheet-Broiler-chickens.pdf

country are treated according to New Zealand standards.

4. It is an offence to boil sentient crayfish alive in New Zealand, carrying a fine of up to $25,000.[24] This is not necessarily the case in the destination country.
5. Crayfish and eels do not even need an Animal Welfare Export Certificate[25] to be exported i.e. there is very little oversight.

Our values

The AJP party ethos is built on five guiding principles that shape our positionality in response to current and emerging issues affecting New Zealanders within the animal welfare policy space. Our values are interwoven to produce robust evidence-based policies, reflecting the views of national and international industry leaders in research and science.

These values are:

- Nonviolence
- Animal Rights
- Equality
- Sustainability
- Just Transition

[24] https://www.legislation.govt.nz/regulation/public/2018/0050/23.0/LMS22832.html

[25] https://www.mpi.govt.nz/export/animals/live-animals-including-livestock/requirement-documents-for-exporting-live-animals/animal-welfare-export-certificates/animal-welfare-export-certification-exemptions/

More about why AJP opposes a reinstatement of livestock export by sea and why we will campaigning for further restrictions on live export by air

Live export by sea

5,867 cows and 41 crew tragically died when Gulf Livestock 1 sank at sea in September 2020 which led to a temporary suspension of livestock export by sea from New Zealand. After an independent review by Michael Heron QC, exports resumed with tighter controls including increased voyage reporting and reduced stocking density on vessels.

Another 128 cows also died in 2020 during the usual course of transport and as a result of the terrible conditions on board. Animal Genetics Trade Association spokesman Dave Hayman has said "Deaths were most often from a broken leg or a joint injury."

MPI have stated that the minimum pen area per head for cattle exported by sea is strongly recommended to be $2m^2$ for the average 600 kg cow. Australian Dr. Lynn Simpson is a veterinarian who has travelled on 57 long haul live export voyages. Dr. Simpson has said "They're pretty tight. They're right up against each other, and they have to choreograph and jostle around to find space. Generally in my experience they can't all lie down at the same time".

A New Zealand veterinarian has described their experience on board a live export ship:
"The cramped nature of the pens and the effluent buildup (both on the floor and on the coats of the cattle) reduced air flow around the cattle, which added to the heat stress. I found it very difficult to alleviate the distress I observed during this period of the journey."
"Despite our best efforts to get all the cattle across the equator alive, two cattle died of heat stress on the journey. Although the two cattle written down on our trip report represent a low mortality rate attributable to heat stress, the pain and distress they and the surviving cattle experienced still haunts me."[26]

26

https://www.parliament.nz/resource/en-NZ/53SCPP_EVI_115891_PP2427/3f9275012e56ee5fd5e145bbc0626c3ca58d8c45

Most of the cows exported have been sent to China.[27] Farmed animals in China have very few laws to protect them in life or at the time of their slaughter. Most cows will spend the rest of their lives on “confinement farms".[28]

Live export by air

3.4 million day-old chicks travel internationally by air annually causing variable welfare compromises to the day-old chicks. Day-old chicks are not able to regulate their own temperature and are subjected to handling, loading, and transporting stress.

This industry takes advantage of the day-old chicks’ ability to survive for up to 72 hours without food and water due to their residual yolk-sac which provides nutrients and hydration, in the absence of feed and water. The composition and size of the yolk-sac depends on various factors and some will last longer than others. While the yolk-sac can provide up to 72 hours of nutrition and hydration, the rate of use is also affected by factors such as genetics and environmental conditions. Some individual chicks will not have adequate sustenance during their journey meaning inadequate nutrition and dehydration which will contribute to their death.

The Ministry for Primary Industries does not routinely report mortality statistics for day-old chicks, so we do not even know how many could not survive the journey. In addition, the Ministry only applies voluntary guidelines to the trade, which are not publicly consulted.

Many will be slaughtered without stunning, which is illegal in New Zealand.[29] China takes the biggest proportion, followed by Bangladesh, Fiji, the Philippines and Malaysia.[30]

In China there are very few laws to protect them during their life or at the time of their slaughter. While colony cages are still legal in NZ, some of the exported chickens will

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[27] https://www.google.com/url?q=https://www.mpi.govt.nz/export/animals/live-animal-and-germplasm-export-statistics-and-reports/&sa=D&source=docs&ust=1693736960451342&usg=AOvVaw1LrjcU7IHWXWDBsa4-sTmh

[28] https://www.dairyglobal.net/world-of-dairy/farm-visits/going-bigger-big-scale-dairy-farming-a-main-trend-in-china/

[29] https://www.ciwf.org.uk/media/5235309/Welfare-sheet-Broiler-chickens.pdf

[30] https://safe.org.nz/our-work/animals-in-aotearoa/live-export-trade/

live in cages that have been outlawed in New Zealand. Many will be slaughtered without stunning, which is also illegal in New Zealand.

August 2025

Ensuring Adequate Living Conditions and Environmental Standards

The Animal Justice Party Aotearoa NZ (AJP) is working towards a future without animal agriculture. In the meantime, we are committed to addressing the widespread neglect of shelter, housing and environmental conditions that cause immense suffering to farmed animals. Despite existing legal protections, animals across New Zealand are routinely exposed to harsh weather, overcrowding and barren environments that deny them the ability to express natural behaviours. AJP is calling for urgent reforms to ensure farmed animals are afforded basic protections, dignity and care.

The Animal Welfare Act 1999 legislates that animals must be provided with "adequate shelter" and "the opportunity to display normal patterns of behaviour." However, these requirements are often poorly defined and inadequately enforced. Throughout New Zealand, animals frequently lack protection from harsh weather conditions, with many farms having removed natural shelter like trees that historically provided protection.

This is particularly concerning given New Zealand's varied and often extreme weather pattern. For example the Code of Welfare: Dairy Cattle (2019) states “Dairy cattle in New Zealand are exposed to extreme weather (heat, cold, rain, snow and wind)” and that this can “create welfare risks, leading to hyper- or hypothermia.”[31]

Intensive winter grazing represents one of New Zealand's most pressing animal welfare and environmental challenges, particularly in southern regions. This practice forces animals to graze fodder crops in small allocated areas, often resulting in them standing in deep mud for extended periods. Animals frequently lack adequate shelter, dry lying areas or protection from harsh weather conditions. Pregnant and nursing animals are especially vulnerable, facing increased risks of health issues and pregnancy complications. The practice not only compromises animal welfare but also causes significant environmental damage through soil degradation, waterway pollution and increased greenhouse gas emissions.

Indoor housing systems, particularly in intensive pig and poultry farming, frequently subject animals to poor air quality, excessive noise and overcrowding. These conditions not only cause physical health issues but also prevent animals from expressing natural

[31] https://www.mpi.govt.nz/dmsdocument/46024-Code-of-Welfare-Dairy-cattle

behaviours such as rooting, nesting and forming normal social relationships. Colony cages for hens, despite being marketed as an improvement over battery cages, still fundamentally deny birds their basic behavioural needs. The lack of environmental enrichment in these systems leads to psychological distress and abnormal behaviours.

AJP supports comprehensive legislative reform to improve the living conditions of farmed animals in Aotearoa. We support the integration of kaitiakitanga principles in developing environmental standards for farming operations, acknowledging that true environmental protection benefits both animals and people. We advocate for clear, enforceable housing and shelter standards, the phasing out of intensive confinement systems, and a ban on technologies that exacerbate suffering. These changes are essential to upholding the intent of the Animal Welfare Act and ensuring that, for as long as animal farming continues, the welfare of animals is no longer compromised by inadequate or exploitative conditions.

Key Objectives:

1. Guarantee meaningful shelter and environmental protection for all farmed animals, with enforceable standards for shade, shelter, and temperature regulation.
2. End intensive confinement practices, including colony cages, farrowing crates, and winter grazing systems that deny animals freedom of movement and comfort.
3. Reform housing and welfare codes to prioritise natural behaviours and psychological wellbeing, ensuring enriched environments, space and social interaction.
4. Prevent the use of technologies that worsen animal suffering, by banning AI-driven systems designed to increase confinement and enforcing ethical oversight for all tech involving animals.

May 2025

Ensuring Adequate Nutrition and Health Standards

The Animal Justice Party Aotearoa NZ (AJP) is committed to transforming New Zealand's approach to animal nutrition and health in farming systems. While our long-term goal is to end animal agriculture, immediate reform is needed to address the widespread welfare harms caused by inadequate feeding practices, compromised health management and overreliance on pharmaceuticals in industrial farming. AJP supports stronger regulation, enforcement and a shift in priorities from production efficiency to animal well-being.

Despite the Animal Welfare Act 1999 requiring proper and sufficient food and water for animals, many farming practices in New Zealand compromise animals' nutritional needs. This creates a notable contradiction between the feed restriction practices permitted under industry-specific welfare codes and the broader principles of the Act itself, which emphasises animals' right to proper nourishment and natural behaviors.

New Zealand's dairy industry presents specific nutritional challenges, with high-producing dairy cows often struggling to meet their metabolic demands through pasture alone. This can lead to conditions like milk fever and ketosis.[32]

Similarly, in intensive poultry and pig operations, animals may receive diets that maximise growth or production at the expense of their overall health and welfare. For example, the parent birds of meat (broiler) chickens are often placed on restricted feeding programs to prevent them from becoming too heavy, which would impair their reproductive capabilities.[33] This creates welfare concerns as these birds have been genetically selected for rapid growth and have strong appetites, yet are fed only about 25-50% of what they would eat if given free access to food.

The practice of winter break feeding on forage crops has drawn significant criticism due to animal welfare concerns. This practice often leaves cattle and sheep standing in deep mud for extended periods, without adequate shelter, creating both welfare and environmental issues.[34]

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[32] https://rumenox.co.nz/understanding-ketosis-in-new-zealand-dairy-cows-causes-symptoms-diagnosis-and-treatment/

[33] https://www.abdn.ac.uk/news/opinion/why-are-chickens-used-for-breeding-kept-hungry/

[34] https://safe.org.nz/our-work/animals-in-aotearoa/mud-farming/

The prevalent use of antibiotics in New Zealand farming, particularly in intensive operations, masks underlying welfare issues rather than addressing their root causes. This practice contributes to the growing global threat of antimicrobial resistance while failing to address the fundamental problems of overcrowding and stress that compromise animal health.

AJP supports urgent reform to ensure that farmed animals receive proper nutrition, appropriate health care and protection from preventable suffering. We call for clear and measurable welfare standards, improved enforcement and a shift away from farming systems that prioritise productivity at the expense of animal well-being. These measures are essential to reducing current harms while progressing toward the complete replacement of animal agriculture with ethical, sustainable alternatives.

Key Objectives:

1. Establish enforceable nutrition and health standards that prioritise animal well-being over production outcomes, including requirements for adequate feed quality, body condition monitoring, and appropriate nutrition for vulnerable animals.
2. Phase out harmful and intensive practices such as winter grazing and overcrowding that compromise nutrition, increase disease risk, and cause suffering.
3. Strengthen animal health protection through preventive care, robust disease management protocols and independent oversight of animal health outcomes.
4. Tackle antibiotic overuse by regulating the routine use of antimicrobials, addressing underlying welfare issues, and contributing to the fight against antimicrobial resistance.

May 2025

Animal Breeding and Reproduction Reform

The Animal Justice Party Aotearoa New Zealand (AJP) is committed to transforming animal breeding and reproduction practices to uphold the rights, personhood and welfare of animals. While our long-term vision is to end all forms of animal agriculture, we recognise the urgent need to reform current breeding practices, which often prioritise production and profit at the expense of animal health, dignity and wellbeing. This policy addresses the ethical, legal and welfare concerns associated with genetic manipulation, reproductive control and growth-promoting technologies used in modern farming.

There are pressing issues arising from intensive breeding programmes and reproductive technologies that have often prioritised productivity at the expense of animal health and well-being. A prime example of this is the breeding of broiler chickens, who have been genetically selected to grow at an unnaturally rapid rate, leading to severe health problems such as skeletal disorders and heart failure. Our policy advocates to reverse these trends.

Current breeding practices often involve invasive and problematic procedures, including forced artificial insemination and semen collection. These practices subject animals to significant psychological stress and physical manipulation without their consent. In dairy farming, cows are repeatedly impregnated through artificial insemination to maintain milk production. Similarly, in pig farming, boars are subjected to forced semen collection for artificial insemination programs. These practices reduce animals to reproductive machines, ignoring their sentience and dignity.

Bobby calves are a direct result of dairy industry practices. These male calves, typically separated from their mothers within 24 hours of birth, face severe welfare concerns including premature maternal separation, inadequate nutrition and early slaughter. AJP has identified this as an inherent systemic issue requiring immediate reform. While working towards the complete abolition of dairy farming, we will advocate for strict interim measures alongside transparent reporting of bobby calf statistics, enhanced monitoring of welfare standards and significant penalties for non-compliance.

The breeding of animals for fibre and skin products, such as sheep for wool and cows for leather, presents similar ethical concerns. Selective breeding for traits like increased wool yield or specific hide qualities often compromises animal welfare. For example, merino sheep bred for fine wool production frequently suffer from increased flystrike

risk, leading to the cruel practice of mulesing.[35] AJP calls for the end of breeding practices that prioritise product qualities over animal wellbeing across all farming contexts.

We aim to create a paradigm shift in animal agriculture towards methods that respect the rights, personhood and welfare of animals. This policy represents a crucial step towards a more compassionate and sustainable future in animal farming, one where the welfare of animals is given equal consideration to agricultural output.

AJP supports urgent reform of animal breeding and reproduction practices to reflect a rights-based approach that recognises animals as sentient beings, not commodities. We call for the phasing out of invasive and exploitative technologies, greater transparency and accountability in the dairy and livestock industries, and investment in alternatives that do not rely on animal exploitation. These measures are essential to reducing current harms and progressing toward a future where animals are no longer farmed, but respected as individuals with their own interests, autonomy, and right to live free from harm.

Key Objectives:

1. End harmful and invasive reproductive practices that violate animal autonomy, including routine artificial insemination, forced semen collection and other procedures that reduce animals to reproductive tools.
2. Reform breeding systems to prioritise animal health and dignity, phasing out genetic selection for extreme traits that compromise wellbeing (e.g. rapid growth, excessive milk yield).
3. Protect the rights and welfare of animals born as by-products of the farming system, including bobby calves, through enhanced care standards, transparent reporting, and investment in non-lethal alternatives.
4. Ban technologies that compromise animal welfare, including growth hormones, chemical growth promotants and unregulated genetic engineering, and establish independent ethical oversight for any emerging biotechnology involving animals.

May 2025

[35] https://www.tierschutzbund.de/en/animals-topics/animal-welfare-in-everyday-life/merino-wool/

Ensuring Humane Handling and Management

The Animal Justice Party Aotearoa New Zealand (AJP) is committed to ending harmful animal handling practices and advancing a system of care that upholds the dignity, rights and welfare of all animals used in agriculture. While our ultimate goal is to abolish all animal farming, we call for urgent reforms to eliminate cruel procedures, ensure prompt access to veterinary care, and establish humane handling standards rooted in compassion and respect for sentient beings.

Industrial farming often prioritises profit over animal welfare, leading to practices that cause unnecessary pain, distress and harm. AJP advocates for the elimination of harmful handling practices, ensuring access to veterinary care and legislative reform that prevents cruelty.

Many common farming practices are invasive, painful, and unnecessary. AJP calls for an immediate end to:

- Debeaking of hens, a practice that causes significant pain and distress.
- Routine surgical mutilations, including tail docking, teeth clipping and mulesing, unless medically necessary and performed with anaesthesia.
- Harmful practices in pig farming, such as "thumping" (blunt force trauma), ear notching and tail docking.

By prohibiting these practices, this policy aims to protect farmed animals from unnecessary suffering while promoting alternative methods that prioritise their wellbeing.

Farmed shellfish and other marine animals are frequently overlooked in welfare legislation. AJP supports the implementation of humane practices in aquaculture, including:

1. Enforcing standards that minimise stress and injury during farming.
2. Regulating overcrowding and ensuring the wellbeing of marine species in aquaculture systems.

AJP advocates for an urgent shift away from entrenched cruelty in animal farming towards a system grounded in care, accountability and legal recognition of animals' rights. We call for the immediate prohibition of inhumane practices and enforcement of

meaningful standards to protect animals from suffering. These reforms are essential steps in our broader transition away from animal agriculture and towards a just, plant-based future where all animals are free from exploitation.

Key Objectives:

1. End cruel and routine mutilations such as debeaking, tail docking, teeth clipping and mulesing, unless medically necessary and carried out with full pain relief.
2. Establish legally binding humane handling standards to prevent fear, stress and injury to farmed animals across all stages of their lives.
3. Ensure timely and accessible veterinary care for all farmed animals, recognising their right to medical treatment and relief from suffering.
4. Extend legal protections to aquatic animals in aquaculture systems, including enforceable welfare standards that prevent overcrowding and minimise distress.

May 2025

Minimising Animal Suffering during Slaughter

The Animal Justice Party Aotearoa NZ (AJP) is committed to protecting the rights and dignity of animals exploited in the agricultural system, including at the point of slaughter. We reject the idea that killing animals for products can ever be truly humane, as it inherently violates their right to life. While working towards the complete abolition of animal slaughter, we advocate for urgent reforms to eliminate the most egregious practices, improve transparency and enforcement in slaughter facilities, and reduce suffering where it still occurs.

AJP advocates for the elimination of all inhumane methods of slaughter, as existing practices often prioritise efficiency and profit over animal welfare. We believe that no animal should endure unnecessary pain, fear or distress at the end of their life.

A particularly cruel and unnecessary example is the widespread culling of male chicks. AJP is committed to ending this practice by implementing alternatives, such as in-ovo sexing and support for plant-based and cellular egg technologies, that prevent the mass killing of animals deemed uneconomical.

To ensure transparency and improved compliance with animal welfare regulations, AJP calls for mandatory video surveillance in all slaughterhouses. Independent oversight and access to footage by veterinary and law enforcement agencies is essential to prevent cruelty and ensure accountability.

AJP recognises that no reforms can make the slaughter of sentient beings truly just. However, while animal killing continues, we will fight for measures that reduce suffering, increase accountability and challenge the legitimacy of an industry built on exploitation. These reforms are essential steps in our broader mission to replace animal agriculture with compassionate, sustainable systems that respect the rights and lives of all animals.

Key Objectives:

1. Prohibit all slaughter methods that cause unnecessary suffering and fail to render animals immediately unconscious and insensible to pain.
2. Ensure transparency and accountability in slaughterhouses, including mandatory video surveillance, independent monitoring and law enforcement access to footage.

3. Ban the mass culling of male chicks and invest in ethical alternatives such as in-ovo sexing and support for plant-based and cellular egg technologies.
4. Advance the transition to a plant-based food system that eliminates the need for animal slaughter entirely. See AJP Transition to a plant-based economy policies.

May 2025

Position Statement: Towards a Cruelty-Free and Sustainable Fashion Industry

The Animal Justice Party Aotearoa NZ envisions a future where fashion is free from animal exploitation and environmental harm. We recognise that the use of animal-derived materials such as leather, wool, fur, down and exotic skins perpetuates cruel and unsustainable practices. Animals exploited for fashion, like those farmed for food or fibre, are sentient beings with their own personhood and rights, and their lives must not be commodified for human use

Key Positions:

1. **Complete Phase-Out**: Ban on production, sale and import of:
    a. Leather and exotic skins
    b. Wool and possum fur
    c. Down and feathers
    d. Animal-derived accessories (bone, horn, pearls)
2. **Industry Transition Support**:
    a. Financial assistance for businesses transitioning to ethical alternatives
    b. Research funding for sustainable materials
    c. Training programs for workers in affected industries
3. **Te Tiriti Partnership**:
    a. Consultation with Māori textile experts
    b. Support for traditional, cruelty-free fibre practices
    c. Investment in Māori-led sustainable textile initiatives
4. **Interim Measures**:
    a. Mandatory labeling of animal-derived materials
    b. Import restrictions from countries with poor animal welfare
    c. Transparency requirements for production methods

May 2025

Ensuring the welfare and protection of companion animals

Ending Exploitative Breeding and Trade of cats and dogs

The Animal Justice Party Aotearoa NZ (AJP) advocates for comprehensive reform of companion-animal breeding practices in Aotearoa. The current legislative and regulatory framework does not adequately address companion-animal overpopulation or protect the wellbeing of animals bred for sale. The commercial breeding of companion animals contributes to an oversupply of dogs and cats, places heavy strain on shelters and rescue organisations, and diverts potential adopters from animals already in need of homes. AJP believes in a future where there is no commercial breeding. No animal should be bred, sold, or traded in ways that compromise their welfare or contribute to the ongoing euthanasia of unwanted animals.

Until that future is law, we're calling for strict controls to reduce the number of animals bred and reduce suffering in the meantime. The objectives below are a floor, not a finish line, a transitional path towards ending commercial breeding altogether, not a permanent settlement.

Key Objectives:

1. Companion animals must be desexed unless:
    a. The animal is owned by a licensed and registered breeder operating under a robust, enforceable licensing system that is fit for purpose. Registered breeders must meet stringent eligibility criteria, comply with an enforceable code of conduct, and be subject to regular monitoring and ongoing compliance requirements; or
    b. A registered veterinarian determines that desexing would be medically detrimental to the animal's health. In such cases, the animal must undergo a veterinary review every three years to confirm that the medical risk remains unreasonably high. The animal's guardian must also take all reasonable steps to prevent the animal from mating or being placed in circumstances where mating could occur.
2. Implement educational programs that highlight the issue with excessive breeding, the importance of desexing companion animals, and promote the adoption of rescued animals as the best way to bring a companion animal into your family.

3. End the intensive breeding of companion animals by banning the sale of animals in ‘pet’ stores or through online traders, excluding verified rescue animals.
4. End the practice of businesses calling themselves 'registered breeders' on the strength of a local permit alone
5. Introduce a cap on the number of breeding dogs/cats held at any one property and a cap on the number of litters a breeding animal can have per year and over their lifetime.
6. Ensure that when companion animal ‘factories’ close, the animals are rehomed through appropriate rescue groups, and not killed.
7. Develop enforceable protocols to ensure that people cannot use the Internet or other media to deceive the public regarding the origin of listed animals, and hold publishers accountable for advertisements that do not comply with legislation.
8. Implement traceability for companion animals as legally required evidence that all animals at the point of sale or transference of ownership are desexed and microchipped
9. Update Section 127 of the Animal Welfare Act 1999, to include that inspectors are enabled to inspect shelter, water and food receptacles, alongside the inspection of animals, and allocate sufficient resources to enforce animal protection laws, including annual inspections and audits of breeders and breeding facilities.
10. Update current legislation in regard to ‘infringeable offence for failing to comply with a notice of instruction’ under Section 130 of the Animal Welfare Act 1999, with the aim of increasing penalties such as lifelong bans on breeding and owning animals, offering reoffending prevention and rehabilitation programmes

Background

Shelters across Aotearoa, New Zealand are overwhelmed by an excess of unplanned litters and surrendered animals; a crisis closely tied to unregulated breeding. Investigations into so-called “puppy mills” and unregulated breeding operations have exposed welfare harms including poor living conditions, inadequate socialisation, and puppies being separated from their mothers too early, leading to behavioural and potentially serious health problems later in life. Puppies sold online are often unsocialised and not desexed, increasing the risk that they will contribute further to the population problem once they enter new homes.[36]

High-volume breeding also perpetuates demand for breeds with known health issues. For example, short-nosed (brachycephalic) breeds like pugs and bulldogs are prone to

[36](2019, September 18). *Puppy Mills*. SAFE | for Animals; SAFE For Animals. https://safe.org.nz/our-work/animals-in-aotearoa/puppy-mills/

chronic breathing problems due to their conformation, creating ongoing health burdens for guardians and welfare concerns for the animals themselves.

Even in established breeding systems, genetic conditions can emerge later in life, resulting in substantial veterinary costs and, in some cases, abandonment. This dynamic exacerbates shelter overcrowding and highlights the need for tighter controls. Companion animals should be regarded as sentient companions rather than mere commodities.

MPI Codes and Welfare Expectations

Under the Animal Welfare Act 1999[37], MPI Codes of Welfare set minimum care standards for animals, including breeders and those selling animals. Codes for dogs and cats specifically recommend desexing for animals not intended for breeding, noting that desexing significantly reduces the number of unwanted animals entering shelters and improves overall population control. MPI guidance makes clear that desexing should be performed before puberty for dogs not used for planned breeding, and cats should be desexed early to prevent unplanned litters[38].

These Codes also outline responsible breeding practices and highlight the need to consider the availability of suitable homes before breeding. However, enforcement mechanisms and penalties remain weak, leaving gaps in protection and oversight.

SPCA and Responsible Regulation

SPCA New Zealand supports improved legislative tools to mitigate welfare harms arising from unregulated breeding. This includes stronger regulation and inspection of breeding establishments, mandatory microchipping and desexing prior to sale, and licensing systems for breeders with enforceable welfare standards. SPCA opposes the purpose-breeding of companion animals for sale in ‘pet’ shops and online retailers unless those animals are desexed, vaccinated, and microchipped.[39]

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[37] *New Zealand Legislation*. (2025). New Zealand Legislation. https://www.legislation.govt.nz/act/public/1999/142/en/latest/#DLM49664

[38]for, M. (2023, October 8). *Code of Welfare: Companion Cats | NZ Government*. Code of Welfare: Companion Cats | NZ Government. https://www.mpi.govt.nz/animals/animal-welfare/codes/all-animal-welfare-codes/code-of-welfare-companion-cats

[39] *Pet Shops and the Online Retailers Selling Animals*. (2018). Spca.nz. https://www.spca.nz/advocacy/position-statements/article/pet-shops-and-the-online-retailers-selling-animals

SPCA's national desexing strategy highlights the importance of widespread desexing in controlling animal populations. Over a two-year campaign, more than 36,000 animals were desexed, which is estimated to have prevented more than 135,000 unwanted kittens and puppies from being born.[40] SPCA believes desexing is a key element of responsible companion animal guardianship. The companion animal population is estimated to include approximately 1.26 million cats and 830,000 dogs.[41] An estimated 146,000 cats and 221,000 dogs are yet to be desexed. In addition, some animals are not desexed until after they have already produced one or more litters, further contributing to unwanted breeding and population growth. Because of this, SPCA has a 10 year plan to desex 15,000 animals per financial year in an attempt to help stop the overwhelm of unwanted litters by establishing low cost desexing programmes, collaborative relationships with councils and rescues, and promoting education and owner compliance[42].

NZ Veterinary Perspective

The New Zealand Veterinary Association (NZVA) emphasises that desexing companion animals helps prevent overpopulation and reduces the number of animals abandoned or surrendered to shelters. NZVA guidance encourages desexing cats and dogs not intended for breeding and supports microchipping to aid reunification and population management. This reflects a broad professional consensus that desexing is a cornerstone of responsible pet ownership and population control in New Zealand.[43]

National Context and Pet Population

According to Companion Animals New Zealand's 2024 NZ Pet Data Report, approximately 63% of New Zealand households have companion animals. The SPCA estimates that approximately 88% of owned cats are desexed, with only 49%

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[40] *Ambitious targets exceeded in two-year desexing campaign SPCA New Zealand*. (2024). Spca.nz. https://www.spca.nz/news-and-events/news-article/twoyeardesexingwrap

[41]CANZ. (2025, March 2). Companion Animals New Zealand. Companion Animals New Zealand. https://www.companionanimals.nz/articles/0tb82z5g2q0j06wnf5bppa3vyutvt4

[42] *About SPCA's National Desexing Programme*. (2021). Spca.nz. https://desexing.spca.nz/about

[43] *Responsible pet ownership*. (2025). New Zealand Veterinary Association. https://nzva.org.nz/public/pets/responsible-pet-ownership/

microchipped[44]. Despite widespread responsible pet ownership, unowned, stray, abandoned, and irresponsibly bred animals continue to place significant pressure on animal shelters, rescue organisations, local authorities, and native wildlife. These figures demonstrate New Zealanders' strong commitment to companion animals while highlighting the need for policies that promote responsible ownership, reduce unwanted litters, and improve long-term animal welfare outcomes.

July 2026

[44] *Involve your Council*. (n.d.). https://desexing.spca.nz/councils

Promoting Responsible Ownership and Care

Work in Progress - Sept 2026

Compassionate Pound and Shelter Reform

The Animal Justice Party Aotearoa NZ (AJP) advocates for a compassionate pound and shelter system where rehoming and no-kill are the national default, not the exception. We believe every dog is an individual with an inherent right to life, safety, and respect. Our policy tackles the root causes of overcrowding while transforming pounds into transparent, well-funded spaces dedicated to giving every dog the best possible chance of finding a home.

We challenge the current framework that allows thousands of dogs to be killed in the pound system each year. This is happening across councils with varying resources and policies, and largely out of public sight. In Auckland alone, 60%[45] of dogs entering the pound system between July 2024 and June 2025 were euthanised, that is 6,079 dogs. Behind every one of those numbers is an individual who deserved better.

AJP calls for urgent legislative and operational reform that places the best interests of each individual dog at the centre of pound policy. Every dog entering the pound system in Aotearoa deserves to be treated as an individual, not a statistic. Our goal is straightforward: fewer dogs killed, more dogs with a home.

Key Objectives:

1. Implement legislation that requires pounds to act in the best interests of the animals in their care.
2. Ban the use of bolt guns entirely, with no exceptions.

[45] *Pūrongo ā-Tau Annual Report*. (2024). https://ourauckland.aucklandcouncil.govt.nz/media/0yjcq3gt/final_animal-management-annual-report-2024-2025_29-08-25.pdf

3. Mandate consistent, transparent public reporting, including the number of animals received and of that, how many are reunited with guardians, adopted or euthanised.
4. Strengthen reunification processes so guardians can quickly and easily locate missing dogs
5. Remove financial barriers to reclaiming dogs through flexible fee payment options
6. Shift from traditional temperament testing to behaviour assessment in calm, home-like foster environments
7. Enhance temporary animal housing conditions and capacity through increased funding and support for rehoming facilities
8. Formalise relationships with rescues and shelters
9. Foster community-led animal welfare initiatives across Aotearoa
10. Promote and invest in widespread, accessible desexing programmes
11. End breed-based euthanasia and ensure all dogs are assessed as individuals
12. Ensure euthanasia is only ever used as an absolute last resort, and never on a healthy dog. Where it is required, it must be carried out in a way that minimises suffering.

Background

Aotearoa's pound system is facing significant and urgent challenges. Shelters and council-operated facilities are under pressure, resulting in large numbers of dogs being euthanised each year. Further to this, inefficient operating procedures contribute to the challenges. In Auckland alone, more than half of the dogs entering the pound system, between July 2024 and June 2025 were euthanised, creating widespread public fear that reporting a lost or wandering dog may result in its death. This erosion of trust demonstrates a system that is not functioning as it should for animals or communities. As a nation that regards dogs as beloved companions[46], it is critical that we address the failings of the current system and work collectively to achieve better outcomes.

[46] Forrest, R., Awawdeh, L., Pearson, M., & Waran, N. (2023). Pet Ownership in Aotearoa New Zealand: A National Survey of Cat and Dog Owner Practices. *Animals*, *13*(4), 631. https://doi.org/10.3390/ani13040631

AJP recognises that uncontrolled breeding is a primary driver of pound overcrowding. The sheer volume of incoming dogs currently hinders what can realistically be achieved in terms of individual welfare, enrichment, behaviour assessment, and rehoming. Because of this, AJP places strong emphasis on legislative and policy reform that mandates or facilitates widespread desexing, supported by adequate public funding. This includes public education initiatives that explain the consequences of failing to desex, the benefits of desexing, and promoting affordable/subsidised desexing schemes and how guardians can access these services. Addressing these upstream issues is essential to reducing intake pressures and preventing unnecessary euthanasia.

Causes

The rise in dog impoundments across Aotearoa reflects a combination of structural, social, and economic pressures. Interruptions to desexing initiatives during the COVID-19 pandemic[47], the ongoing cost-of-living crisis, housing instability, and limited access to pet-friendly rentals all contribute to guardians surrendering or losing dogs[48].

These factors demonstrate that the pound system does not operate in isolation. It sits within a wider context of social attitudes, economic pressures, and public policy gaps. While upstream issues such as desexing and responsible guardianship must be addressed urgently, immediate reform within pounds is also needed to ensure better welfare outcomes for dogs currently entering the system.

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[47] OurAuckland. (n.d.). *Animal Management annual report reveals impact of COVID-19 pandemic*. OurAuckland. https://ourauckland.aucklandcouncil.govt.nz/news/2022/09/animal-management-annual-report-reveals-impact-of-covid-19-pandemic/

[48] *Preventing Pet Abandonment & Cruelty in NZ - Pet Rescue NZ*. (2025, December 24). Pet Rescue New Zealand. https://www.petrescue.org.nz/preventing-pet-abandonment-cruelty-in-nz/

Under the Dog Control Act 1996[49], councils follow a mandated protocol for managing impounded dogs, including efforts to contact guardians and a minimum holding period. If fees are unpaid or guardians cannot be reached, councils may rehome or euthanise the dog. Without systemic reform, this framework continues to produce poor outcomes in an environment already overwhelmed by high intake numbers and limited capacity. In March 2026, the government announced a review of the Dog Control Act to "crack down on roaming and uncontrolled dogs[50]." As of writing, the scope of the review is still to be determined but will include "looking at clauses which may be imposing barriers or resource pressure on councils, as well as penalties and consequences for non-compliant dog owners, desexing obligations, and stronger powers for council officers."

Community and Stakeholder Engagement

A sustainable and humane pound system depends on strong community involvement and shared responsibility. This requires public education about responsible guardianship, dog welfare, and the importance of desexing. It also requires active collaboration among all stakeholders, including guardians, breeders, veterinarians, trainers, shelters, rescues, iwi, community groups, educators, and government agencies.

High euthanasia rates undermine public confidence and discourage people from reporting wandering dogs, creating further risks to animal and community safety. Building trust through transparency, compassion, and consistent best-practice standards is essential. Community-led fostering, rehoming assistance, and safety initiatives can ease pressure on pounds and improve outcomes for dogs. AJP also

[49] New Zealand. (1996). *Dog Control Act 1996* (Public Act 1996 No 13). New Zealand Legislation. https://www.legislation.govt.nz/act/public/1996/13/en/latest
[50] *Government orders review of Dog Control Act*. (2026, March 21). The Beehive. https://www.beehive.govt.nz/release/government-orders-review-dog-control-act

supports measures that require guardians reclaiming their dogs to demonstrate responsible care, such as agreeing to desexing and meeting Animal Welfare Act standards.

Connection to Existing AJP Policies

Several existing AJP policies provide a foundation for pound reform:

- **Commissioner for Animals:** An independent Commissioner would provide impartial oversight across council pound practices and ensure animal welfare remains central to local government decision-making
- **Sentience and Legal Status:** AJP's advocacy for recognising animals as sentient individuals with inherent value directly underpins the case for treating every pound dog as someone, not something

Pawsitive Change Campaign

AJP's Pawsitive Change Campaign was born from the real stories of dogs like Robbie and Benny, who lost their lives in a system that should have saved them. Launched in 2024 and named in their memory, the campaign began with a clear, practical demand: that every council pound in Aotearoa must report consistently and transparently on the dogs in their care, including how many arrive, and how many are reunited, rehomed, fostered, or killed. That data is the foundation for everything else. Without it, we cannot know where the system is failing most, or where urgent support is needed. The policy proposals in this document build directly on the campaign's aims, and New Zealanders who want to add their voice can sign our petition at animaljustice.org.nz/pawsitive-change.

Our commitments

Improving outcomes for impounded dogs requires both system-wide reform and strengthened community responsibility. Pounds must adopt humane, modern practices, while guardians and the broader community must play a more proactive role in preventing abandonment and supporting rehoming.

AJP recommends replacing bolt guns with humane euthanasia methods that ensure rapid loss of consciousness and minimal distress, thereby reducing suffering for animals and trauma for staff. AJP also opposes breed-based euthanasia. A dog's life should never be ended on the basis of how they look. Assessment must focus on individual behaviour and temperament, not breed assumptions.

Reunification processes should be strengthened through clear public-facing systems and varied communication methods to help guardians quickly locate missing dogs. Flexible reclaim fee payment options would help remove financial barriers that prevent guardians from reclaiming their dogs, reducing avoidable euthanasia.

A shift away from traditional temperament testing toward assessment in calm, home-like foster environments is also essential for accurately understanding a dog’s behaviour and increasing successful adoptions. Establishing and funding foster networks would support extended holding periods, reduce overcrowding in pounds, and provide dogs with greater stability and wellbeing while awaiting rehoming.

Interim Measures

While broader legislative reform is developed, AJP calls for immediate action:

1. Require all councils to begin consistent public reporting on pound intake, outcomes, and euthanasia rates without delay
2. Issue urgent guidance banning bolt guns across all council-operated facilities
3. Establish subsidised emergency desexing access for guardians in financial hardship
4. Fast-track funding for foster network pilots in high-intake regions

5. Require councils to publish and follow a transparent rehoming pathway before euthanasia is considered for any healthy or treatable dog

Conclusion

AJP's proposed reforms aim to transform Aotearoa's pound system into one that is compassionate, transparent, and centred on the wellbeing of animals and communities. By addressing both the upstream drivers of overcrowding - such as uncontrolled breeding and barriers to desexing - and the immediate weaknesses in pound operations, Aotearoa can move toward a system where far fewer dogs are euthanised and far more experienced care, safety, and positive outcomes. These changes will strengthen public trust, reduce pressure on councils and rescue organisations, and ensure that dogs across the country are treated with the dignity and respect they deserve.

Ensuring the welfare and protection of aquatic species

Equitable Protection for Aquatic Animals

The Animal Justice Party believes that if we say animals matter, our laws need to protect them. New Zealand already acknowledges in legislation that fish, crustaceans, and cephalopods are sentient beings capable of suffering. What we don't yet have are the standards, the enforcement, and the consistency to make that acknowledgement legally binding. We want to close that gap, and ensure that aquatic animals receive the same protection under the law that we extend to animals on land.

What is happening

New Zealand's Animal Welfare Act 1999 names fish, octopus, squid, crab, lobster, and crayfish within its definition of 'animal', and since 2015 has explicitly recognised animal sentience in its purpose. But recognition without enforcement is just words on a page. The Act and its codes of welfare are applied selectively, with significant gaps in oversight and monitoring. For aquatic animals, those gaps are particularly wide. There is no standalone code of welfare for fish in commercial aquaculture or wild capture. Without species-specific standards or adequate resourcing, aquatic animals are effectively left out of the protection that the law promises them.

The picture is even more woeful for decapod crustaceans such as shrimp and prawns, and cephalopods such as cuttlefish, which currently fall outside the legal definition of 'animal' under the Act. Scientists now have strong consensus that fish can feel pain,[51] and the evidence for sentience in many aquatic invertebrates continues to grow.[52] Our law has simply not kept pace with these developments.

This matters at scale. Globally, somewhere between 78 and 171 billion farmed fishes,[53] 1.1 and 2.2 trillion wild fin-fishes are killed each year for human consumption,[54] alongside 25 trillion of shrimp.[55] What New Zealand does in its own waters, and the standards it holds its industries to, is within our power to change.

What we stand for

[51] https://sentientmedia.org/do-fish-feel-pain/

[52] de Souza Valente, C. Rethinking Sentience: Invertebrates as Worthy of Moral Consideration. J Agric Environ Ethics 38, 3 (2025). https://doi.org/10.1007/s10806-024-09940-2

[53] Mood, A., Lara, E., Boyland, N. K., & Brooke, P. (2023). Estimating global numbers of farmed fishes killed for food annually from 1990 to 2019. Animal welfare (South Mimms, England), 32, e12. https://doi.org/10.1017/awf.2023.4

[54] Mood, A., & Brooke, P. (2024). Estimating global numbers of fishes caught from the wild annually from 2000 to 2019. Animal Welfare, 33, e6. doi:10.1017/awf.2024.7

[55] https://aquaticanimalalliance.org/welfare-guide

The Act already acknowledges that aquatic animals are sentient. We believe that acknowledgement should carry real legal weight. The full legal protection of the Animal Welfare Act should apply consistently to all the aquatic animals it covers, backed up by adequate resourcing and independent oversight and enforcement rather than left to the commercial industries to police themselves.

We would also extend the legal definition of 'animal' to include all decapod crustaceans and cephalopods. Shrimp, prawns, and cuttlefish are not commodities. The scientific evidence of their capacity to suffer is compelling, and growing, and our law should reflect it.

Beyond that, we would establish dedicated, enforceable welfare standards for aquatic animals in commercial settings, covering handling, housing conditions, and humane slaughter, equivalent to the protections that already apply to terrestrial animals. Both the Ministry for Primary Industries and the SPCA currently lack the resourcing to monitor and enforce animal welfare effectively. Legal protection on paper is symbolic only without resourcing and funding available to uphold and enforce them.

Our objectives

- Ensure the Animal Welfare Act protects all aquatic animals it legally defines, with consistent enforcement across all commercial industries
- Extend the definition of 'animal' to include all decapod crustaceans and cephalopods, in line with the scientific evidence on sentience
- Establish dedicated, enforceable codes of welfare for aquatic animals in commercial settings, equivalent in standard to protections for terrestrial animals (see AJP Policy Treatment Standards for Aquatic Animals)
- Require ethical and painfree' handling and slaughter standards for aquatic animals used in commercial fishing and aquaculture until it is phased out (see AJP Plant based economy policies - as animal agricultural-based industries are phased out it is important to support workers and communities in the transition to enable a respectful and flourishing future for all).
- Adequately resource and fund animal welfare enforcement agencies to monitor and uphold legal protections for aquatic animals - including cameras and onboarding monitors.
- Establish independent oversight of overall animal welfare compliance for both aquatic animals and terrestrial animals, removing the conflicts of interest that arise when industry is left to regulate itself

July 2026

Phasing Out Aquaculture and Fish Farming

DRAFT as of 13 September 2026

Phasing Out Animal Aquaculture[56] and Fish Farming

The Animal Justice Party (AJP) advocates for the complete phase-out and total abolition of all animal farming, including finfish cephalopod, and shellfishand octopus aquaculture, which are inherently cruel and ecologically unsustainable.The AJP recognises aquatic animals as sentient beings with inherent value and rights, opposing their exploitation, industrial rearing, and commercial slaughter.

Fish have been legally recognised as sentient beings, which means they are capable of feeling pain, stress and positive emotional states. The Animal Welfare Act 1999 (the AWA) and the Code of Welfare for Commercial Slaughter apply to farmed fish and for any fish that are intended to be held or transported live. The party firmly opposes investing taxpayer funds into the research and development of new farming enterprises, such as the proposed commercial octopus farms.

There are key factors against the farming of aquatic animals

- **Sentience, and Cruelty and Legal recognition:** Fish and cephalopod molluscs (such as octopuses and squids), and decapod crustaceans (such as crabs, lobsters, and crayfish/kōura) are complex, sentient beings capable of experiencing pain and distress and positive emotional states. Animal sentience was explicitly recognised in the 2015 amendment to the Animal Welfare Act (1999), the AWA definition of 'animal' explicitly extends protection to octopuses, squids, crabs, lobsters, and crayfish under specific regulatory frameworks. Farming them in intensive, high-density conditions deprives them of their natural behaviours and causes immense psychological and physical suffering therefore should be banned.
- **Slaughter Concerns and Regulatory gaps:** There is currently no binding statutory code of welfare for farmed fish species. The New Zealand Salmon Farmers' Association has developed a voluntary welfare standard for farmed salmon in New Zealand. Methods

[56] References to "aquaculture" throughout this policy strictly refer to **animal aquaculture** (the breeding, rearing, and harvesting of aquatic animals, including finfish, crustaceans, and molluscs). The AJP explicitly supports non-animal marine farming, such as native macroalgae, microalgae, and seaweed cultivation, as key components of a plant-based economy.

used for slaughtering fish and cephalopods (such as asphyxiation or freezing in ice slurry) cause extreme, prolonged suffering because these animals do not die instantly.

- **Ecological and Food Chain Impact:** Cephalopods and many farmed fish are carnivorous. Farming them requires mass quantities of wild-caught fish for feed, placing severe, unsustainable pressure on wild marine ecosystems and exacerbating overfishing. Aquaculture systems produce heavy wastewater discharge (fecal matter, chemicals, excess feed) that not only pollutes the immediate fish farm environment but also the surrounding marine environments, while the risk of farmed animals escaping threatens biosafety and local ecosystems.
- **Public Health Risks:** Intensive farming environments act as vectors for pathogens and zoonotic diseases.

Policy Directives & Action Statements

Precautionary Protections for Invertebrates, Decapods and Bivalves

Legal Recognition & Protection: The AJP advocates for amending Section 2 of the Animal Welfare Act 1999 to extend full, unconditional statutory animal welfare protections to all cephalopod molluscs (such as octopuses and squids) and decapod crustaceans (such as crabs, lobsters, and crayfish/kōura) across all commercial, agricultural, and slaughter settings.

Immediate Spatial Moratorium: The AJP demands an immediate statutory moratorium on the spatial expansion, resource consent renewals, and new permit applications for all commercial animal aquaculture operations - including finfish, decapod crustacean, and bivalve (mussel, oyster, clam, scallop) farming.

Precautionary Phased Transition: While scientific research into non-cephalopod invertebrate sentience continues, the absence of full scientific certainty will not delay protective action. Existing commercial bivalve and crustacean operations will be integrated into the compulsory phased transition strategy alongside finfish farming, shifting ocean infrastructure toward non-animal marine applications (such as native macroalgae and wild ecosystem restoration).

Prohibition of New Species Development: A total, preventative ban will be enacted against establishing new animal aquaculture industries in Aotearoa New Zealand waters, including proposed commercial octopus or decapod farming enterprises.

Prevention of Secondary Wildlife Harms

Aquaculture infrastructure inflicts severe, indirect mortality and behavioral disruption on non-farmed wild animals:

- Entanglement Mitigation: Marine farm lines, spat-catching ropes and predator-exclusion nets present severe entanglement and drowning hazards to migrating cetaceans (including Bryde's, Humpback, and Southern Right whales), seals, sea lions and diving seabirds.
- Spatial Barriers: Coastal farm installations disrupt natural foraging, echolocation, and migration routes of native marine species, including local dolphin populations.
- Bycatch: The forage-fish harvest supporting carnivorous aquaculture operations inflicts massive collateral damage via industrial trawling bycatch.

Artificial Intelligence (AI) and Industrial Automation Governance

AJP recognises that Artificial Intelligence is rapidly transforming management systems across farming and aquaculture in Aotearoa New Zealand.

- Rejection of Productivity Automation: The AJP strictly opposes the deployment, commercial use, or public funding of AI technologies, automated feeding systems, computer-vision tracking and autonomous slaughter systems designed purely for economic efficiency, yield optimisation or increasing stocking densities.
- Integration into National Governance: The AJP demands the immediate inclusion of explicit animal welfare protection principles within all national AI governance frameworks to prevent industrial cruelty from becoming algorithmically or economically entrenched.
- Transition Alignment: AI technologies must not be used to "welfare-wash" or prolong inherently unsustainable farming operations. Any temporary use of non-invasive monitoring tools during the phase-out period must strictly serve immediate harm minimization and animal welfare monitoring.

Key objectives

1. Legally prohibit the expansion of existing aquaculture operations and outlaw the establishment of new marine farming enterprises (including cephalopods (e.g. octopus), finfish, decapod crustacean (crabs, lobsters, crayfish/kōura) and bivalve farming) in Aotearoa New Zealand waters.
2. Amend the Animal Welfare Act 1999 to guarantee full statutory protection for all cephalopods and decapod crustaceans, while applying the Precautionary Principle to ensure a lack of full scientific certainty regarding bivalve sentience is never used to justify commercial exploitation or delay welfare protections.

3. Ban taxpayer funding, government subsidies, and public research grants for aquaculture expansion, industrial automation and artificial intelligence technologies designed to intensify animal farming, placing oversight under an independent Commissioner for Animals.
4. Protect wild marine life by dismantling marine farm infrastructure that causes entanglement (protecting migrating whales, dolphins, seals, and seabirds) and ending the destructive harvesting of wild forage fish used for aquaculture feed.
5. Establish a statutory 'Just Transition' framework to support aquaculture industry workers shifting toward sustainable, non-animal marine industries (such as ocean restoration and plant-based macroalgae/seaweed production, ocean restoration, and wild sanctuary monitoring).

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- Radio NZ https://www.rnz.co.nz/news/politics/562801/aquaculture-animal-welfare-code-anti-kiwi-oceans-and-fisheries-minister-shane-jones-says
- The Fish Site
- VAWA (Veterinarians for Animal Welfare Aotearoa)

https://www.vawa.co.nz/post/octopus-farming-that-s-a-no

Humane Treatment Standards for Aquatic Animals (Interim until phasing out occurs)

Work in progress: Interim until above happens - mandate pre-stunning before slaughter for all aquatic animals, ban drowning in air and cooking alive, prohibit injurious handling tools,and require humid environments during transport until stunning.

Marine and Freshwater Habitat Conservation

Work in progress: Protect aquatic habitats from commercial exploitation including bottom trawling, seismic testing and agricultural runoff, establish marine reserves covering30% of maritime areas, impose strict liability for water contamination, and combat plastic pollution. (Checkagainst climate policies)

International Marine Animal Protection

The Animal Justice Party believes our oceans deserve more than management. They deserve protection. Aotearoa New Zealand is a Pacific nation, bound to the moana by culture, identity, and geography. Our closest neighbours have already led the way: in 2024, Indigenous leaders from Aotearoa, the Cook Islands, Tahiti, Tonga, Hawaii, and Rapanui signed He Whakaputanga Moana, recognising whales as beings with inherent rights. We want New Zealand to honour that vision with action, ending our complicity in international marine cruelty and becoming a genuine champion for the animals who live in our shared ocean. This shift in the international animal welfare and protection policy environment highlights the growing recognition of animal welfare as a critical issue on the global stage.

What is happening

Commercial whaling has never stopped. Japan, Norway, and Iceland continue to kill whales despite a 40-year-old international moratorium,[57] using a regulatory loophole that allows for lethal scientific research. Since that moratorium came into force, Japan alone has killed over 24,000 whales,[58] Norway over 16,000,[59] and Iceland over 2,000.[60] [61](International Whaling Commission, 2024.) Norway's 2026 quota is set at 1,641 minke whales, an increase of 235 on last year, when the quota was set at 1,406.[62] [63] Japan withdrew from the International Whaling Commission in 2019 to resume coastal commercial whaling and added fin whales, a threatened species, to its commercial hunt in 2024.[64] This is not tradition. It is industry, subsidised by governments and sustained by political manoeuvring.

Each year in Taiji, Japan, hundreds of dolphins are driven into a cove, selected for marine parks or killed. In the 2024/25 season, 286 dolphins were slaughtered and 94 taken captive, according to on-the-ground monitoring by the Dolphin Project and Japanese animal advocates.[65] In the Faroe Islands, similar slaughter and trauma happens each year in the ‘grind’, in 2026 over 700 dolphins were killed.[66] Families are separated. Calves lose their mothers. The animals who are released carry the trauma of what they have witnessed.

Sharks are killed by the millions globally, often for their fins, and in some places culled to protect beachgoers despite evidence that shark culls are both ineffective and ecologically damaging. Seal hunting continues in Canada, Namibia, and elsewhere, driven by commercial fur and skin

[57] https://www.ifaw.org/press-releases/40-years-after-the-whaling-ban-whales-continue-to-die
[58] https://www.oceancare.org/en/stories_and_news/yahoo-japan-selling-toxic-whale-meat-online/
[59] https://insideclimatenews.org/news/14042026/norway-reopens-commercial-whaling-despite-demand-decline/
[60] https://www.ifaw.org/international/press-releases/iceland-controversial-whale-hunt-resume-within-days
[61] https://iwc.int/management-and-conservation/whaling/total-catches
[62] https://uk.whales.org/2025/02/11/government-in-norway-to-allow-killing-of-more-whales/
[63] https://oceanographicmagazine.com/news/ngo-s-condemn-norway-s-increased-2026-whaling-quota/
[64] https://www.marineinsight.com/japan-kills-worlds-second-largest-whale-in-commercial-whaling-program/
[65] https://www.dolphinproject.org/campaigns/save-japan-dolphins/
[66] https://seashepherd.org/2026/05/28/sea-shepherd-crew-arrested-706-dolphins-killed-in-faroe-islands/

markets. And across the world, fishing subsidies worth hundreds of billions of dollars each year prop up an industry that is pushing many marine populations toward collapse. Over one-third of global fish stocks are now fished at biologically unsustainable levels.[67]

However, change is happening. On 28 March 2024, Indigenous leaders from Aotearoa, the Cook Islands, Tahiti, Tonga, Hawaii, and Rapanui signed He Whakaputanga Moana, a historic declaration recognising whales as legal persons with inherent rights, including the right to freedom of movement, a healthy environment, and the ability to thrive alongside humanity. Released publicly at Waitangi in February 2026, this declaration is grounded in Te Ao Māori and Polynesian values that have always understood the ocean as a web of relationships, not a warehouse. A parliamentary bill, the Tohorā Oranga Bill, was introduced to Parliament in early 2026 seeking to give that vision legal force.[68]

We stand with this global ethical shift. Aotearoa should be leading the way, not watching from the sidelines.

This growing ethical commitment to marine animals also acknowledges their role in sustainable development and human wellbeing. Global animal protection is, however, a complex challenge requiring collaboration across countries, cultures, and legal systems.

What we stand for

Existing regulatory frameworks often prioritise conservation and biodiversity, rather than the welfare of individual animals. This leaves many marine species, especially those not endangered or economically significant, without legal protection.

Ending commercial whaling and the Taiji dolphin drive hunts/ Faroe Islands 'grind'. There is no justification for these practices in the 21st century. New Zealand should use every diplomatic tool available to pressure Japan, Norway, and Iceland to end commercial whaling, and should advocate loudly and consistently at every international forum for a permanent, enforceable end to both whaling and drive hunts.

Transforming the International Whaling Commission. The IWC was built for a different era. It should be reformed and expanded into a broader International Marine Animal Protection body with a genuine conservation mandate, the power to enforce protections, and the inclusion of dolphin and small cetacean welfare within its scope.

Supporting He Whakaputanga Moana and the Tohorā Oranga Bill. New Zealand should formally endorse the whale personhood declaration, support the Tohorā Oranga Bill, and work with

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67 https://www.worldanimalprotection.org/latest/blogs/marine-wildlife-at-risk-how-we-can-stop-ocean-exploitation/

68 https://ecojurisprudence.org/initiatives/he-whakaputanga-moana-declaration-for-the-ocean-treaty/

Pacific partners to translate its vision into binding international protections. Whales communicate, grieve, form lifelong bonds, and navigate across oceans. They deserve legal recognition as the individuals they are.

Banning shark culling and shark fin imports. Shark culling does not make beaches safer and it causes serious harm to already stressed marine ecosystems. New Zealand should prohibit shark culling and ban the importation of shark fins and shark products.

Opposing international seal hunting. New Zealand should oppose commercial seal hunting internationally and ban the importation of seal products from commercial hunts.

Redirecting fishing subsidies. Subsidies that prop up destructive fishing practices should be phased out and redirected toward the retraining and transition support of fishing industry workers into sustainable roles, including marine restoration, aquaculture of non-sentient species, and coastal stewardship.

Expanding marine protected areas. New Zealand has some of the world's largest ocean territory. We should be world-leading in its protection. We support a significant expansion of fully protected marine areas where ecosystems and the beings who live within them can recover.

Review of International Trade Law. Review New Zealand's international trade law and policy instruments and challenge any provisions that undermine marine animal protection.

Our objectives

- End commercial whaling through sustained diplomatic pressure and international advocacy
- Call for an end to the Taiji dolphin drive hunts and the Faroe Islands 'grind' and the use of dolphins in captive entertainment
- Reform the International Whaling Commission into a comprehensive marine animal protection body
- Formally endorse He Whakaputanga Moana and support the Tohorā Oranga Bill
- Ban shark culling and the importation of shark fins and shark products
- Oppose commercial seal hunting internationally and ban seal product imports
- Redirect harmful fishing subsidies toward worker transition and marine restoration
- Significantly expand marine protected areas within New Zealand's ocean territory
- Review and challenge international trade laws that undermine marine animal protection

Created July 2026

Eliminating the Use of Animals in Science

Ending Animal Testing

The Animal Justice Party of Aotearoa NZ (AJP) aims to ban all harmful forms of animal experimentation. AJP will commit to promoting the use of compassionate research.

Animal experimentation often utilises harmful and invasive processes that routinely involve subjecting animals to painful and stressful procedures. The rate at which animal-based models of experiments fail to translate to human-based models is high. This creates an opportunity to find alternative methods that can prove to be more effective, accurate and ethical. For example, there are emerging alternatives to many forms of animal experimentation, such as cell cultures and computer simulations. By requiring the use of alternatives to animal testing wherever possible, we can foster a culture of innovation and advancement in the scientific field that does not come at the expense of animals.

According to New Zealand Anti Vivisection Society (NZAVS), Aotearoa's primary charity defending animals used in science, there are major problems with animal testing:

Animals are unreliable and unscientific models for predicting outcomes in humans because:

- Animal biology does not translate to human biology.
- What works in animals often does not work in humans.
- What is safe for animals can be dangerous for humans.
- What does not work in animals may save human lives.
- Animal experiments are expensive and time consuming.

Animal experiments are harmful to humans and animals alike. Animal-free methods often outperform animal experimentation and these animal-free technological methods of testing can enable innovative ways to overcome the limitations of animal research.

Key objectives:

1. Campaign for the phasing out the use of harmful animal experimentation and invasive testing and research methods.
2. Campaign for funding towards the 3Rs (replacement, reduction and refinement) in the use of animals for science.

3. Campaign for the reform and adaptation of legislative requirements for invasive animal testing in all sectors and for the advancement of scientific knowledge through the use of human biology based tests.
4. Campaign for the compassionate use of animals in teaching, including by replacing the use of animals where they are not required.
5. Campaign to ensure, in collaboration with research organisations/institutes, that animals currently in animal testing and research spaces are rehomed rather than killed when deemed surplus to requirement.

Animal experimentation facts

During 2021, over 300,000 animals were used in experiments in the name of Research, Testing and Teaching (RTT).[69] An additional 178,569 animals were bred for RTT purposes but not used and were subsequently killed.[70] In this same report for 2021, 8% of the total animals reported were killed for their tissue but did not undergo prior manipulation and 39% of the total animals manipulated died or were killed during or after these procedures.[71]

A significant proportion of research and testing is conducted on farmed animals. In 2019 MPI reported 50% of all animals used in RTT were farmed animals.[72]

In 2021, over 3,000 guinea pigs were used in experiments and 97% of them were killed. The percentage of guinea pig deaths has consistently been more than 91% since 2010. With knowledge that animal to human models fail over 90% of the time, these experiments are unethical and fundamentally flawed.- nzavs.org.nz

'Nearly 97 percent of rabbits and rodents were 'dead or euthanized' following manipulation'[73]

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[69] Ministry for Primary Industries (2023). *2021 Statistics on the Use of Animals in Research, Testing and Teaching in New Zealand* https://www.mpi.govt.nz/dmsdocument/56998-Statistics-on-the-Use-of-Animals-in-Research-Testing-and-Teaching-in-New-Zealand-in-2021/

[70] ibid

[71] ibid

[72] Ministry for Primary Industries (2021). *2019 Statistics on the Use of Animals in Research, Testing and Teaching in New Zealand* https://www.mpi.govt.nz/dmsdocument/44776-Statistics-on-the-use-of-animals-in-research-testing-and-teaching-in-New-Zealand-in-2019/

[73] Ministry for Primary Industries (2025). *2023 Statistics on the Use of Animals inResearch, Testing and Teaching in NewZealand* https://www.mpi.govt.nz/dmsdocument/67062-2023-Statistics-on-the-Use-of-Animals-in-Research-Testing-and-Teaching-in-New-Zealand/

Putting an end to harmful animal experimentation in the name of agriculture and drug testing is of utmost priority.

Strategic Priorities

With many animal experiments being harmful to animals and/or unreliable in their applicability to humans, we need a greater focus on the development of ethical and human relevant scientific experimentation methodologies. The end goal is to replace all harmful animal experiments with alternative methods. Removing regulations that require harmful animal experimentation is paramount to ensuring that this goal is reached, allowing scientific research to be more effective and accurate. We need to make sure that ethics aren't compromised in animal research.

There are many alternatives to animal testing. According to Katy Taylor, author of 'Animal Experimentation: Working Towards a Paradigm Change' (2019) improvements in non-animal models have accelerated in the past 30 years. There are now alternatives for a significant proportion of the standard methods that are harmful towards animals. However, the replacement of the current techniques is delayed by lack of funding, bureaucracy and the deep entrenchment of animal testing in science. Moving past these barriers will be important, not only for the rights and welfare of animals but to enable the innovation and advancement of scientific research.

It is important when researching treatment and cures in the biomedical field that human-based research is prioritised, as this is the most reliable way to generate accurate data. Researching alternatives such as micro-dosing, microfluidic devices, and computer programs will increase the efficacy of viable alternatives to animal testing. AJP will campaign to ensure priority is given to adequately fund the replacement, reduction and refinement of animals in science, at the same time as we advocate to end all harmful animal experimentation.

By the enactment of forward-thinking legislation that provides for scientific institutions to transition from outdated animal testing methods to non-animal-based methods for research, testing and teaching purposes, New Zealand has an opportunity to become a global leader in the advancement of science, as well as in its standards of animal welfare.

Phase out and legislative transition plans are the key components urgently required to accelerate legal and regulatory certainty and enable the global harmonisation of legislation and regulations.

It is completely unethical for research institutions to breed thousands of animals each year,to perform painful and distressing experiments on them, and then euthanise and discard them.

3Rs Explainer:

Animal experiments are widely required to comply with the 3Rs principle (Replacement, Reduction, Refinement) to provide a framework for ethical decision making. In essence, the 3Rs principle demands that wherever alternative methods exist, they have to be used (replace), the number of animals used has to be kept to the bare minimum to achieve the objectives of the research (reduce) and the treatment of the animals has to be improved with measures taken to mitigate any pain, suffering or distress (refine).[1]

Whilst the 3Rs principle is widely recognised internationally by scientists as a moral obligation, it fails, however, to provide any legal protection for the animals being subjected to the experiments[2] or establish any legal principles governing what ethical research conduct actually means.[3] It is also of itself a barrier to change, given that it begins from an animal testing standpoint."

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https://nzavs.org.nz/problems-with-the-animal-mode
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Animal Experimentation: Working Towards a Paradigm Change on JSTOR
ANZCCART Resources
Ending Animal Experimentation Policy, created September 2023

[1] The principles of the 3Rs concerning animal experimentation were postulated in 1959 by William Russell and Rex Burch in a book entitled "*The Principles of Humane Experimental Technique*", Methuen & Co Ltd, London https://www.worldcat.org/title/1486173

[2] T Beauchamp and D DeGrazia, *Principles of Animal Research Ethics* (Oxford University Press 2020) Preface X and 81.

[3] Hope Ferdowsian, L. Syd M Johnson, Jane Johnson, Andrew Fenton, Adam Shriver and John Gluck, `*A Belmont Report for Animals?*` (2020) 29(1) Cambridge Quarterly of Healthcare Ethics 19-37, 21 https://www.cambridge.org/core/journals/cambridge-quarterly-of-healthcare-ethics/article/belmont-report-for-animals/F4518E13F2FE89A7719C5082A7FB44F8

The environmental impacts of animal-based research

The Animal Justice Party of Aotearoa New Zealand (AJP) aims to ban all harmful forms of animal experimentation. AJP commits to promoting the use of compassionate research.

Animal experimentation often utilises harmful and invasive processes that routinely involve subjecting animals to painful and stressful procedures. The rate at which animal-based models of experiments fail to translate to human-based models is high. This creates an opportunity to find alternative methods that can prove to be more effective, accurate and ethical, for example, there are emerging alternatives to many forms of animal experimentation such as cell cultures and computer simulations. By requiring the use of alternatives to animal testing wherever possible, we can foster a culture of innovation and advancement in the scientific field that does not come at the expense of animals.

However, the traditional, and still dominant, ethical view, which is mirrored in most animal testing legislation and regulations, is that the use of animals in research is acceptable in order to achieve scientific, public safety and medical goals, provided that animal suffering is minimised and that the human benefits gained could not be obtained by utilising alternative methods. By its very nature, animal testing required by law is in tension with the goal of animal welfare legislation, which is to protect animals from violations of their welfare.

Animal-based research isn't just an ethical issue. It also has significant environmental impacts that demand attention. The environmental cost of maintaining these practices contradicts commitments to sustainability and climate action.

The main environmental impacts of animal experimentation include:

5. ***High Resource Consumption***: Animal research facilities use large amounts of water, electricity, and specialised food for the animals. The need to maintain specific environmental conditions (e.g., temperature control and ventilation) further increases energy use.

   Animal research requires significant energy resources. Research facilities consume up to ten times more energy per square metre than office buildings[74] due to stringent requirements, including controlled ventilation, temperature regulation, pathogen barriers, specialised lighting, and power-intensive equipment.

6. ***Waste Production and Pollution***: Research generates substantial biomedical waste that requires careful management and disposal. This includes both biological waste (animal carcasses, excrement, bedding, and uneaten food) and hazardous materials (syringes, needles, contaminated materials, and chemical waste).

   When animals used in research are disposed of, their remains may be classified as hazardous waste, depending on the type of studies they were involved in. This can include exposure to chemicals, infectious agents, or radioactive materials.

[74] https://animalfreescienceadvocacy.org.au/issues/environmental-impact/

A key concern is the gap in awareness and safety measures between laboratory personnel, who are trained to handle such materials, and external waste management or transportation services, which may not have the same level of knowledge about the risks involved. If these third-party handlers are unaware of potential hazards, improper disposal could lead to environmental contamination or public health risks.

Proper disposal methods often involve incineration or other resource-intensive processes. During incineration, particulate matter, organic compounds, pathogens, and radioactive materials may be released into the surrounding environment, posing significant human health risks, including cancer and respiratory illnesses. Environmental concerns include air and water pollution, acidification, and greenhouse gas emissions.

7. ***Carbon Footprint***: The transportation of animals, supplies, and research materials contributes to carbon emissions. Additionally, maintaining breeding colonies and research facilities adds to the overall carbon footprint.

8. ***Land Use and Habitat Destruction***: Large-scale breeding and housing of research animals requires land, which could otherwise be used for conservation or more sustainable purposes.

9. ***Chemical and Pharmaceutical Pollution***: Animal testing is particularly used for safety (toxicity) and efficacy testing of chemical compounds. Beyond toxicity testing, animals are also used to assess the effectiveness of sanitation, disinfection, and sterilisation processes.

    A key concern is that some chemicals used in these experiments may have unknown hazardous or carcinogenic properties, posing risks not only to the animals but also to researchers, waste handlers, and the environment. Many chemicals tested in laboratories may not yet have fully understood toxicological profiles, potentially exposing both animals and humans to unknown dangers.

    Industries that conduct toxicity and pharmaceutical testing on animals can contribute to groundwater and soil contamination if their waste management practices are inadequate. Improper disposal of chemical agents, pharmaceuticals, and biological waste can lead to hazardous substances leaching into the environment, causing long-term environmental hazards and public health risks.

Key Objectives:

Interim measures, while we work towards the AJP Policy Ending Animal testing, include:

5. AJP will encourage the minimisation of the environmental impacts of animal-based research by requiring all research facilities, laboratories, and institutions engaged in animal research and testing, including academic, governmental, and private-sector organisations, to implement sustainable practices, reduce waste, and ensure compliance with relevant environmental regulations.

6. AJPANZ will support the adoption of the following measures by all research facilities and institutions:

    5. *Reduce, Refine, Replace (3Rs)*: Prioritise alternatives in order to replace animal testing where possible, refine methods to minimise environmental impact and reduce the number of animals used. Strengthen the adherence to the 3Rs.

    6. *Waste Management*: Reduce reuse and recycle materials wherever possible, properly dispose of hazardous and biological waste in compliance with regulations and implement sustainable alternatives for animal bedding and feed where feasible.

    7. *Energy and Resource Efficiency*: Utilise energy-efficient equipment and lighting in animal research facilities and optimise water usage in cleaning, animal care and laboratory operations.

    8. *Sustainable Procurement*: Source laboratory supplies, animal feed and equipment from environmentally responsible suppliers and prioritise biodegradable or recyclable materials in research processes.

    5. *Reduction of Greenhouse Gas Emissions*: Reduce transportation-related emissions by consolidating supply shipments and using local vendors when possible, implementing practices that minimise the release of harmful substances into the air and water.

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May 2025

Eliminating the Use of Animals in Entertainment

The Animal Justice Party opposes the exploitation of animals for commercial entertainment purposes and advocates for ethical treatment of animals in all human-animal interactions. We recognise the mutual benefits of companionship between humans and domesticated animals, but stand against practices that subject animals to stress, harm, or situations that go against their nature for the sake of human amusement. Our vision is for a society that places value on the wellbeing of non-human animals prohibiting practices that exploit or harm them.

While advocating for a complete ban on the use of animals for entertainment and profit, we recognise that there are urgent concerns to address, for example rodeo and greyhound racing.

Our advocacy entails promoting policies that protect the rights of non-human animals in entertainment, emphasising the importance of transitioning to forms of entertainment that align with society's concerns and ethical and moral principles which find all forms of animal exploitation unacceptable.

The policies within this overview focus on ending harmful practices. Policies which provide animals with opportunities to express natural behaviors, form relationships, and experience positive states of well-being will be found in other categories and linked to this document. Holistically, AJP policies promote a vision of a world where animals can thrive in ways that respect their inherent needs and behaviours.

Ban Greyhound Racing **Banned from effect August 1, 2026**

The Animal Justice Party Aotearoa NZ (AJP) is opposed to greyhound racing and is committed to an immediate and complete ban, reflecting our commitment to eliminate the use of animals for human 'sport' and 'entertainment'.

Greyhound racing involves greyhounds chasing a motorised lure at high speed around or along a specialised track while spectators place bets on particular dogs to win. The inherently risky nature of racing, coupled with the industry's dependence on over-breeding, gambling revenue and the incentive to win prize money, has led to a situation where the welfare of racing greyhounds is compromised. Over 40 percent of racing greyhounds suffer injuries while racing; some serious, some lethal. This is the case wherever it occurs, and as a result, greyhound racing remains legal in only a handful of countries.

We do not believe that the greyhound racing industry can be safely regulated for the animals. We also acknowledge the negative impacts of gambling on human mental health, domestic relationships, and financial stability. Over the past decade, three reviews have shed light on concerning practices within the greyhound racing industry in New Zealand, following which the industry has lost its social licence.

AJP advocates for non-violent, community-friendly entertainment that aligns with society's progressive concerns and higher ethical and moral principles and does not exploit and undermine animals' well-being.

Key Objectives:

10. Ban all forms of greyhound racing in Aotearoa NZ.
11. Support the Animal Agencies (SPCA, SAFE, HUHA, DOGWATCH) who are committed to finding loving homes for greyhounds when a ban is enacted.

Interim measures, while we work towards the ban, include:

12. Promote transparency and accountability in relation to deaths and injuries of all greyhounds born into the racing industry both on and off the track.
13. Recommend immediate restrictions to curb the breeding of greyhounds.
14. Call for a reduction on the number of greyhounds each racing kennel is permitted to own.
15. Support the SPCA's 'Good Life' Recommendation.

16. Reallocate government funding and subsidies to transition those employed by the industry into non-exploitative jobs and careers.

August 2025

Ban Horse Racing

The Animal Justice Party Aotearoa NZ (AJP) is opposed to all forms of horse racing and is committed to eliminating the use of animals for human ‘sport’ and ‘entertainment’.

Horse racing for profit includes flat racing, jumps racing, and harness racing. Horse racing in New Zealand is less associated with a sense of glamour of the past and is increasingly controversial owing to the inherent cruelty and risks involved. Every year, despite efforts to improve safety and regulate the industry, hundreds of horses suffer pain, stress, injuries, and even death as a result of being raced.

Contrary to popular belief, horses do not willingly participate in racing; many have to be coerced into the starting gates, highlighting the inherent lack of consent in the activity.

The use of whips, tongue ties, spurs, and other tools, including performance-enhancing drugs, to control and push horses to their limits only exacerbates their suffering, both physically and psychologically. For example, in July 2024, in one week two thoroughbreds collapsed and died at the end of their races from heart attacks. The practice of "wastage," where uncompetitive or excess animals are killed, further underscores the disregard for the lives of these animals.

AJP advocates for non-violent, community-friendly entertainment that aligns with society’s progressive concerns and higher ethical and moral principles, and does not exploit and undermine animals’ well-being

Key Objectives:

10. Ban all forms of horse racing in Aotearoa NZ.

    Interim measures, while we work towards the ban, include:

11. Ensure full transparency and accountability by having a public birth to death registry for all horses born into the racing industry, whether these horses perform in official events or not.
12. Decrease the number of race meetings to alleviate the pressure on horses and reduce the frequency of injuries and fatalities associated with racing.

13. Prohibit cruel practices and tools, such as the use of whips, tongue ties and spurs.
14. Prohibit the racing of horses under three years of age.
15. End the slaughter of ex-racehorses.
16. Provide ex-racehorses with proper care, rehabilitation and rehoming for fulfilling post-racing life.
17. Reallocate government funding and subsidies to transition those employed by the industry into non-exploitative jobs and careers.

September 2024

Ban Rodeo

The Animal Justice Party Aotearoa NZ (AJP) advocates a ban on using animals for 'entertainment' and profit, and is committed to an immediate and complete ban of rodeo events that involve animals.

In New Zealand, approximately 30 rodeo events are held every summer, featuring activities such as bareback bronc riding, saddle bronc riding, bull riding, steer wrestling, barrel racing, team roping, and calf roping. These events involve significant risks to animal welfare, resulting in injuries and fatalities.

To entertain the public, rodeo animals are subjected to chasing, grabbing, prodding, tackling, wrestling, and roping. Their heads and tails are twisted, and normally gentle animals are forced into bucking frenzies through the use of spurs and irritating flank straps, both of which cause significant physical and psychological distress to the animals.

During rodeo events, animals can suffer from torn ligaments, broken bones (often requiring euthanasia), cardiac arrest, bruising, and internal damage. Even without physical injuries, animals experience significant stress and fear, especially calves who are particularly vulnerable. Additionally, there is a lack of transparency in rodeo training sessions, suggesting that many more animals are likely injured away from public scrutiny.

Rodeos inherently involve cruelty, and we believe that they cannot be made safe through regulation. These events promote and normalise violence against animals, dulling society's sensitivity to animal suffering. This is particularly concerning for children who learn a skewed perception of "acceptable" animal treatment, shaping their long-term attitudes towards animal welfare.

AJP advocates for non-violent, community-friendly entertainment that aligns with society's progressive concerns and higher ethical and moral principles, and does not exploit and undermine animals' well-being.

Key Objectives:

9. Ban all forms of rodeo activities involving animals.

Interim measures, while we work towards the ban, include:

10. Change advertising practices to remove 'family-friendly' messaging.
11. Implement a rapid phase-out of all rodeo events within a specified timeframe to eliminate this source of animal cruelty.
12. Increase funding and support for cruelty-free community sporting events.

September 2024

Ban Recreational Hunting and Hunting Competitions

The Animal Justice Party Aotearoa NZ (AJP) is opposed to recreational hunting, including hunting competitions, and is committed to a complete ban. Recreational hunting and hunting competitions cause death and suffering to animals, and undermine efforts to promote respect and compassion for all.

Recreational hunting involves the pursuit and killing of animals for ‘sport’. This practice not only causes unnecessary suffering to animals but also fosters a culture of violence and desensitisation towards animal life. Significant suffering is inflicted upon animals: they may endure prolonged pain from injuries before dying, and non-target species often become unintended victims.

Hunting competitions exacerbate ethical concerns by incentivising the rapid, large-scale killing of animals for prizes and recognition. This pressure often leads to inhumane practices and a disregard for animal welfare. Current practices in some New Zealand schools encourage children to participate in the mass killing of animals, often framed as a game or competition, in which violence is normalised and young minds become desensitised to the suffering of living creatures. Activities like 'Toss the Poss' not only disrespect animal life but also teach children to view certain species as disposable, rather than as sentient beings with lives of inherent worth.

Hunting promotes and normalises violence against animals, dulling society’s sensitivity to animal suffering. Instead of fostering a connection with nature and teaching responsible environmental stewardship, hunting promotes a harmful and oversimplified approach to wildlife management.

New Zealand allows the hunting of an arbitrary and wide range of animals including, to name a few, deer, pigs, free-roaming cats, rabbits and various bird species. Seasonal restrictions may apply or licences may be required.

Hunting practices cause significant suffering across various species. For example: many animals are not killed instantly, resulting in painful wounds and prolonged suffering; injured animals that escape often face a slow, agonising death and the use of certain hunting methods, such as traps or particular types of ammunition, can increase the likelihood of non-fatal injuries. In the case of duck hunting, a seasonal activity, an estimated one million birds are affected annually, highlighting the scale of the issue.

These problems are not limited to any single species but are inherent risks in many forms of hunting.

The practice of hunting also disrupts local ecosystems and harms other wildlife in several ways: It can lead to habitat destruction or modification as hunters create access points or use methods that impact the environment; Non-target species may be accidentally injured or killed and the presence of hunters and their equipment can cause stress and behavioral changes in animals, affecting their natural patterns. Importantly, these harmful practices are unnecessary for wildlife management. New technologies, such as wildlife contraception, offer more humane methods for managing wildlife populations without lethal means, and these approaches tend to be more effective at maintaining long-term ecological balance.

Recreational hunting and hunting competitions are ethically indefensible and cause significant animal suffering. AJP advocates for non-violent, community-friendly entertainment that aligns with society's progressive concerns and higher ethical and moral principles, and does not exploit and undermine animals' well-being

Key Objectives:

7. Ban all forms of recreational hunting.
8. Ban hunting competitions.

Interim measures, while we work towards the ban, include:

9. Call for an immediate ban on duck shooting.
10. Call for an immediate ban on the hunting of feral cats.
11. Enforce regulations to prevent children from participating in hunting activities, including 'school gala days'.
12. Strengthen enforcement of existing animal welfare laws.

September 2024

Ban Recreational Fishing and Fishing Competitions

The Animal Justice Party Aotearoa NZ (AJP) is opposed to recreational fishing and fishing competitions. We are committed to an immediate and complete ban on these activities.

Recreational fishing involves catching fish for “sport”. This practice causes significant distress and suffering to fish and other marine life. Fishing competitions exacerbate these issues by encouraging the mass capture and killing of fish for prizes and recognition.

Recreational fishing inflicts considerable suffering on fish, who can experience pain and distress from being hooked, handled, and often released back into the water injured. Non-target species, such as birds, turtles, and marine mammals, can also become unintended victims through bycatch, and entanglement in lost, abandoned or discarded equipment, leading to injuries or death.

Fishing competitions promote the capture of large numbers of fish in a short period, often resulting in unethical practices and significant harm to fish populations. Many fish caught in these events suffer prolonged pain and stress, and their survival rates upon release are low, contributing to ecological imbalance.

Recreational fishing and fishing competitions are ethically indefensible and cause significant suffering to marine life. AJP advocates for non-violent, community-friendly entertainment that aligns with society’s concerns and ethical and moral principles, and does not exploit and undermine animals’ well-being.

Key Objectives:

- Ban all forms of recreational fishing.
- Ban fishing competitions.

Interim measures, while we work towards the ban, include:

- Enforce regulations that prevent children from participating in recreational fishing or fishing competitions.

September 2024

Ending the Use of All Animals for 'Entertainment'

The Animal Justice Party Aotearoa NZ (AJP) is opposed to the use of animals for human 'sport' and 'entertainment' or for gambling profits. We are committed to eliminating activities which exploit and harm animals and/or normalise violence against them.

The exploitation of animals for entertainment stems from humanity's long-standing belief in our dominion over other species. In these situations, profit often takes precedence over animal welfare. As a result, animals are routinely exposed to danger, forced to perform risky acts for human amusement and financial gain. This practice repeatedly jeopardises their safety, health, and lives, treating them as disposable commodities rather than sentient beings deserving of respect and protection.

This policy is a wide and generic policy providing breadth to support standalone policies for specific cases of animal use in entertainment, for example our *Ban Greyhound Racing* policy. This generic policy includes animals in zoos and aquaria, keeping cetaceans in captivity, agricultural and pastoral show animals (for example for riding), or chickens hatched to provide entertainment for children, and ensuring that animals are not reintroduced to circuses and all other uses.

AJP advocates for an end to animal exploitation for artistic, fashion, cultural, sporting or entertainment purposes, and will work toward ensuring no animal is forced into a working life for 'entertainment' and/or gambling purposes.

Key Objectives:

Ban the use of animals for entertainment purposes.

Interim measures, while we work towards the complete ban, include:

3. Ban all forms of animal 'entertainment' that are funded through or support gambling.
4. Call for complete transparency of organisations that currently profit from animals in entertainment.
5. Ban the breeding of all animal species for 'sporting' performance.
6. Ban the forcing of animals to perform at high and peak levels.

7. Implement rigorous inspections of zoos, wildlife parks and aquaria to ensure their facilities and staffing numbers are optimum for the animals.
8. Support those needing help transitioning to alternative careers.

September 2024

The Future of Zoos and Aquariums

The Animal Justice Party (AJP) advocates for a fundamental reorientation of zoos and aquariums away from entertainment-driven models toward facilities that exist to serve the interests of animals themselves. Facilities that currently exhibit animals for public display must transition toward roles centred on rescue, veterinary care, rehabilitation and, where necessary, the provision of lifelong sanctuary.

Where animals cannot be returned to the wild, their environments must be designed to approximate natural conditions as closely as possible, prioritising autonomy, social needs and behavioural expression. Public access, if permitted, must be strictly managed to ensure that it does not compromise animal wellbeing.

The AJP recognises that many species are not suited to captivity under any circumstances. As such, the long-term objective is to significantly reduce and, where appropriate, eliminate the keeping of animals in traditional zoo settings. Technological alternatives, particularly immersive and virtual experiences, should replace the use of live animals for education and entertainment.

Key Objectives

1. **Transition to Animal-Centred Models**
   Phase out practices that prioritise exhibition and profit, supporting the evolution of zoos and aquariums into rescue, rehabilitation and sanctuary-focused facilities.

2. **Restrict New Zoo Establishments**
   Prohibit the establishment of new private zoos and aquariums. In exceptional circumstances where approval is considered, require rigorous pre-licensing assessments, including detailed evaluation of operator suitability, financial capacity and contingency planning for animal care.

3. **End Breeding for Display**
   Ban captive breeding except where it forms part of independently assessed conservation programmes that demonstrably benefit both species survival and individual animal welfare.

4. **Euthanasia Standards**
   Clear distinction between euthanasia conducted in an animal's best interests and that undertaken for management reasons, so that healthy animals are never killed due to management failure or financial constraints.

5. **Mandatory Exit and Transition Planning**
   Require all facilities to maintain legally enforceable exit strategies that specify how animals will be rehomed, transferred or cared for in the event of closure or operational change.

6. **Financial Assurance Requirements**
   Introduce mandatory financial assurance mechanisms to ensure that adequate funds are available for the ongoing care, relocation or rehabilitation of animals if a facility ceases operation.

7. **Develop Exit Pathways for Existing Animals**
   Implement coordinated strategies to relocate animals currently held in zoos and aquariums to accredited sanctuaries or appropriate environments wherever feasible.

8. **Promote Non-Exploitative Alternatives**
   Support the development and accessibility of virtual reality and other immersive technologies as humane alternatives to live animal displays.

9. **Strengthen Transparency and Accountability**
   Mandate full disclosure of animal origins, health status and life histories and prohibit the commercial import and export of live animals for profit.

10. **Regulate Sanctuaries**
    Establish clear legal definitions and accreditation systems to distinguish genuine sanctuaries from commercial enterprises, ensuring animal interests are paramount.

11. **Enhance Welfare Standards**
    Introduce stringent, enforceable welfare standards, particularly for animals exposed to public viewing, recognising the stress associated with human interaction.

12. **Prohibit Animal Performances**
    Ban the use of animals in performances, displays or interactive experiences that compromise their wellbeing.

13. **Redirect Public Investment**
    Prioritise support for wildlife rescue organisations, veterinary services, and rehabilitation programmes over traditional zoos.

14. **Support Ethical Transition Pathways**
    Provide assistance to operators seeking to transition toward non-exploitative models, including the adoption of virtual and educational alternatives.

15. **Promote Ethical and Sustainable Practices**
    Encourage facilities to align all operations, including food provision, with principles of animal justice and environmental sustainability through adopting plant-based options.

Background and Rationale

Zoos and aquariums may unintentionally communicate that it is acceptable to confine wild animals in small or unsuitable enclosures - sometimes in isolation from their own species - for human education or entertainment. Yet such conditions can cause significant harm, as many animals are unable to engage in their natural, species specific behaviours.

The AJP's approach is grounded in the moral significance of individual animals. Whilst biodiversity and ecosystem protection are important, they must not be pursued at the expense of the lives and wellbeing of individual sentient beings. Practices such as forced breeding, confinement in inadequate conditions and the treatment of animals as interchangeable components of conservation strategies are ethically indefensible.

Effective conservation must prioritise the protection and restoration of natural habitats. Without suitable environments for animals to return to, captive breeding programmes offer limited value and may, in some cases, perpetuate harm. Moreover, zoos tend to

favour highly visible or charismatic species,[75] neglecting the broader ecological relationships necessary for functioning ecosystems.

The AJP envisions a future in which human engagement with animals is guided by respect, responsibility and non-exploitation. Transforming zoos and aquariums is a critical step toward this goal, ensuring that animals are no longer used for entertainment purposes, but are instead protected as individuals with intrinsic value.

Defining Zoos and Sanctuaries

Facilities that house animals vary widely in purpose and practice, often using overlapping terminology that obscures important ethical distinctions.

- **Zoos and aquariums** are typically commercial enterprises that display animals to paying visitors, sometimes incorporating conservation or educational activities alongside entertainment functions.

- **Sanctuaries**, by contrast, are dedicated to the protection and care of animals, without breeding, trading, or exploiting them for profit. Whilst some may allow visitors, animal interests must always take precedence.

Given the blurred boundaries between these categories, regulatory focus should be directed toward the underlying purpose of the institution - whether it exists primarily for animals or for commercial gain.

Conservation Considerations

Although zoos often claim to contribute to conservation, and prevent some species from extinction, evidence suggests that only a small proportion of their resources is directed

[75] https://zslpublications.onlinelibrary.wiley.com/doi/abs/10.1111/izy.12159
https://www.sciencedirect.com/science/article/abs/pii/S2211973616300708

toward meaningful conservation outcomes.[76] Furthermore, most animals held in captivity are not endangered and reintroduction programmes are limited in scope and success.[77]

Captive environments cannot replicate the complexity of natural ecosystems and animals bred in such conditions frequently struggle to survive when released.[78] This raises serious questions about the effectiveness and ethical justification of captivity based conservation models.

Animal Welfare Concerns

Confinement in artificial environments can lead to significant physical and psychological harm. Many captive animals exhibit signs of distress, including repetitive behaviours, self-harm, and abnormal aggression. In some cases, these symptoms are managed pharmacologically rather than addressed at their source.[79]

Additionally, practices such as the killing of "surplus" animals highlight the commodification inherent in zoo systems.[80] Even in well-resourced facilities, captivity restricts animals' ability to engage in natural behaviours, form social bonds and exercise autonomy.[81]

Education and Public Engagement

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[76] J Keulartz *Captivity for Conservation? Zoos at a Crossroads* Journal of Agricultural and Environmental Ethics (2015) 28 335-351 https://link.springer.com/article/10.1007/s10806-015-9537-z
S Coghlan and APA Cardilini *A critical review of the compassionate conservation debate* Conservation Biology (2022) 36(1) e1376
https://doi.org/10.1002/cobi.13760.https://theconversation.com/in-defence-of-zoos-how-captivity-helps-conservation-56719
https://conbio.onlinelibrary.wiley.com/doi/10.1111/conl.12762
https://www.bornfree.org.uk/resource/zoos-financing-conservation-or-funding-captivity/

[77] https://zslpublications.onlinelibrary.wiley.com/doi/abs/10.1111/izy.12159
https://www.nationalgeographic.com/animals/article/predators-captivity-habitat-animals

[78] https://www.theguardian.com/australia-news/2022/nov/21/animals-bred-in-captivity-develop-physical-changes-that-may-hinder-survival-in-the-wild-research-finds

[79] https://www.nytimes.com/2021/06/11/opinion/zoos-animal-cruelty.html
https://bioone.org/journals/journal-of-zoo-and-wildlife-medicine/volume-50/issue-4/2018-0147/THE-USE-OF-CITALOPRAM-HYDROBROMIDE-TO-MANAGE-AGGRESSION-IN-A/10.1638/2018-0147.short

[80] https://www.psychologytoday.com/us/blog/animal-emotions/201701/killing-healthy-animals-in-zoos-zoothanasia-is-a-reality

[81] https://www.sciencedirect.com/science/article/abs/pii/S0168159114000550
https://www.sciencedirect.com/science/article/pii/S001671852300146X

Claims that zoos provide meaningful conservation education are not strongly supported by evidence.[82] Visitor engagement is often driven by leisure and social interaction rather than learning and any educational benefits are typically limited.

Emerging technologies offer a more effective and ethical pathway. Virtual and immersive experiences can foster understanding of animals and ecosystems without subjecting animals to captivity.[83] These approaches also allow for broader accessibility and adaptability.

To maintain credibility as educational institutions, facilities must also align their practices, such as food offering, with principles of sustainability and animal protection.

Further Reading
Code of Welfare: Zoos https://www.mpi.govt.nz/dmsdocument/46054-Code-of-Welfare-Zoos
UK's Standards of Modern Zoo Practice (May 2025):
https://assets.publishing.service.gov.uk/media/681494272de62f4a103a828d/standards-of-zoo-practice-2025.pdf
https://www.gov.uk/government/news/animal-welfare-rules-in-british-zoos-set-for-major-overhaul
https://www.alaw.org.uk/blog/2025/08/18/standards-of-modern-zoo-practice-for-great-britain-recent-update/
UK's Standards of Modern Zoo Practice (to take effect from 24 May 2027):
https://assets.publishing.service.gov.uk/media/697393b8d345446f8ce71ea5/Standards_of_modern_zoo_practice.pdf

Related Policies and Positions
Eliminating the Use of Animals in Entertainment Policy
Protection of Indigenous and Non-Indigenous Wild Animals
Legislation and Regulation Reform for Animal Protection Policy

April 2026

[82] NV Nygren and S Ojalammi *Conservation education in zoos: A literature review* TRACE ∴ Journal for Human-Animal Studies (2017) 4 62-76 https://doi.org/10.23984/fjhas.66540 and S Clayton, J Fraser and C Burgess *The Role of Zoos in Fostering Environmental Identity* Ecopsychology (2011) 3(2) https://doi.org/10.1089/eco.2010.0079.
[83] https://www.animalbehaviorandcognition.org/article.php?id=1292
https://www.eurogroupforanimals.org/news/launch-europes-first-virtual-zoo

Addressing and ensuring a good quality of life for working animals

Working Animal Welfare and Retirement

Work in progress: Protect dogs used in police, security, and assistance roles by banning training methods that cause suffering,establishing guaranteed retirement funds covering health and housing, and prohibiting employment of pregnant or lactating females.

Equine Retirement and End-of-Life Care

Work in progress: Mandatory retirement funds for all domestic horses with contributions from every owner, prohibit slaughter ofex-racehorses, and ensure dignified end-of-life care for all equines

City Farm and Sanctuary Standards

Work in progress: Transition city farms into animal sanctuaries that never send animals to slaughter, require ownership licenses for those keeping farm animals for non-production purposes, and ensure proper care standards for large animals in urban settings.

Protection of indigenous and non-indigenous wild animals

The Animal Justice Party (AJP) recognises all wild animals (indigenous and non-indigenous) as individuals with unique needs and value. We believe that within Aotearoa New Zealand both native and introduced animals have a right to live their lives unimpeded and unharmed by human activities. For the purpose of this document, 'wild animal' refers to free-living animals who live outside captivity and without direct human control, including feral animals.

AJP recognises there can be conflicts between endemic and introduced animals, while emphasising the need for solutions that prioritise compassion and protection. We reject divisive language, hunting and the glorification of trapping and killing animals for conservation purposes. Fundamentally, wild animals deserve the same rights to liberty, health, and freedom from harm as domesticated animals, and this should be reflected in law by specifically including them under the protection of the Animal Welfare Act, rather than considering them "pests" for eradication.

The health and integrity of these ecosystems are of value to New Zealanders and necessary to uphold the Crown's obligations under Te Tiriti o Waitangi, and are also vital for the flourishing of wild animals. For these reasons, AJP supports compassionate and just efforts to mitigate the threats that our ecosystems face.

AJP's policies for the protection of wild animals would best be implemented alongside a transition to a plant-based economy. This is important for three key reasons. Firstly, much of the funding for 'pest' control is allocated specifically to protect animal agricultural interests from disease vectors, particularly targeting possums and stoats which can carry bovine tuberculosis that affects farm animals.[84] This risk would naturally be eliminated with the end of animal farming. Secondly, the focus on invasive species neglects the devastating impact that habitat loss has had on native fauna, which was primarily driven by the need to create pasture for animal farming.[85] Eliminating animal

[84] TBfree is co-funded by the Crown (appropriated via MPI's 'Biosecurity: Control of Bovine TB' vote) and by the dairy, beef, and deer sectors through levies on milk solids, cattle/deer slaughter, velvet, and live exports - roughly a 40% government / 60% industry split. See OSPRI. (n.d.). Funding the TBfree programme. https://www.ospri.co.nz/our-programmes/the-tbfree-programme/funding/; New Zealand Treasury. (2025). Supplementary Estimates of Appropriations 2024/25: Vote Agriculture, Biosecurity, Fisheries and Food Safety (includes "Biosecurity: Control of Bovine TB"). https://budget.govt.nz/budget/pdfs/suppestimates/suppest25agbiofifoo.pdf

[85] Julia Haggerty and Hugh Campbell, 'Farming and the environment', Te Ara - the Encyclopedia of New Zealand, http://www.TeAra.govt.nz/en/farming-and-the-environment/print (accessed 15 February 2025); this point is further elaborated under Obective 2.

agriculture could free up enormous amounts of land for habitat restoration, supporting the protection of indigenous species. Thirdly, animal agriculture is the main cause of freshwater pollution, harming wild fish and eels, along with other freshwater species.[86]

Along with environmental protection, AJP supports research and innovation to develop compassionate and protective approaches within conservation practice.

AJP's ultimate vision is a harmonious coexistence between humans and other animals, fostering a society that upholds the wellbeing and protection of all species and protects the taonga status of specific animals in Aotearoa.

Four overarching objectives

Our policy for wild animals is focused on protecting and managing wildlife through humane and sustainable approaches that respect all animals as individuals with inherent value. It is centered around four objectives, each supported by specific proposals:

1. **Use compassionate approaches to manage introduced species**. Implement non-lethal, humane and species-specific methods to address challenges posed by introduced animals while recognising their right to live without unnecessary harm.

2. **Protect and restore natural habitats.** Preserve and enhance the environments where wild animals thrive, using whole-ecosystem approaches that benefit both native and introduced species.

3. **Shield wild animals from human-caused harms**. Mandate practices that minimise the negative impacts of human activities, development and pollution on wild animals and their habitats.

4. **Mitigate natural threats to wild animal populations.** Support research and intervention programs that help protect wild animals from disease, natural disasters and other environmental challenges while respecting natural processes.

August 2025

[86] Wang, W. F. (2024). Eutrophication mechanisms and their impacts on coastal marine ecosystems. International Journal of Marine Science, 14(4), 285–294. https://doi.org/10.5376/ijms.2024.14.0032

Humane management of introduced species

AJP recognises that animals from both native and introduced species are sentient, and have rights to life and welfare. AJP further recognises that humans are responsible for the introduction of non-endemic species to Aotearoa, and as such it is our responsibility to implement the most compassionate solutions where such species pose ecological threats. These should be framed and carried out in the spirit of Te Tiriti o Waitangi.

AJP supports valuing individual animals because they are sentient, not because of their species status as native or non-native. We oppose the demonisation of introduced species, and promote an understanding of them as animals living here as the direct result of human actions. With this in mind, AJP will work to raise awareness of the cruelty of current methods of controlling introduced species.

At the same time, AJP recognises the threat that particular introduced species, alongside habitat destruction and ecological damage caused by humans, pose to our native ecosystems. AJP therefore advocates for humane methods of population control, and the redirection of funds from current 'pest control' initiatives, such as Predator Free NZ,[87] towards research and development of nonviolent forms of population control, such as contraceptives. We acknowledge that new compassionate approaches to conservation are likely to impose additional costs, and that greater funding for the Department of Conservation and Ministry for the Environment are likely to be needed.[88]

AJP will also advocate for ongoing review of the goals, objectives and methodologies of the government's overarching conservation/biodiversity positions and programmes, including definitions of key terms and cost-benefit analyses of different strategies.

Key Objectives:

1. Call for government and government-funded entities to cease the use of unscientific, emotive and vilifying terms (e.g. 'pests') to describe animals and the requisite amendments made to the Animal Welfare Act.
2. Establish higher welfare standards for population control methods.
3. Fund research into nonviolent alternatives to current methods of population control.
4. Create a special task force to plan the phasing out of violent population control methods and work alongside environmental protection agencies to implement

[87] https://predatorfreenz.org/about-us/predator-free-2050/predator-free-2050-vision/

[88] More humane methods already exist, but are not used due to their increased cost. See Beausoleil, N. J., Fisher, P., Warburton, B., & Mellor, D. J. (2010). *How humane are our pest control tools? Part 1: Vertebrate toxic agents and kill traps in mammal species* (MAF Biosecurity New Zealand Technical Paper 2011/01). Wellington: MAFBNZ; Parliamentary Commissioner for the Environment. (2011). *Evaluating the use of 1080: Predators, poisons and silent forests*. Wellington: PCE.

humane management of all species, endemic and introduced. This group would be responsible for developing policies that prioritise humane alternatives while balancing ecological concerns.

5. Implement educational programmes in schools, universities, and communities to promote compassionate management of introduced species.
   See: *Compassionate Education policy.*

August 2025

Ending the use of lethal biological agents and poisons for population control

AJP opposes the use of lethal biological and poisons to control introduced species, for example Rabbit Haemorrhagic Virus Disease (RHDV) and poisons like 1080 and Brodifacoum. Instead, AJP advocates for humane, non-lethal, and species-specific methods of population management.

Poisons and biological agents used for population control frequently cause intense and prolonged suffering, with some poisons and diseases taking hours or days to kill, leading to unnecessary animal distress. Research has shown that some commonly used poisons, such as those with a welfare impact score over 5.5[89], result in slow, painful deaths and must be reconsidered as part of a humane transition in wildlife management. For example:

- In 2018, a nationwide release of Rabbit Haemorrhagic Virus Disease (RHDV) was carried out to reduce wild rabbit numbers.[90] This virus induces acute hepatitis, leading to fever, difficulty breathing, bleeding, convulsions, and ultimately death from multiple organ failure over 2-4 days.[91]
- 1080, a deadly poison, is aerially dropped to kill possums, rats, stoats, wallabies and rabbits,[92] but frequently kills non-target species such as deer,[93] pigs,[94] mice,[95] and hedgehogs; and can also kill domesticated animals such as dogs[96] and

[89] Landcare Research. (2010). "How humane are our pest control tools?" MAF Biosecurity New Zealand Technical Paper No: 2011/01 https://www.mpi.govt.nz/dmsdocument/4009-How-humane-are-our-pest-control-tools
[90] Landcare Research. "Rabbit biocontrol in New Zealand RHDV1 K5". Accessed May 2025. "https://www.landcareresearch.co.nz/discover-our-research/biodiversity-biosecurity/animal-pest-management/rabbit-biocontrol-in-new-zealand-rhdv1-k5/
[91] https://www.mpi.govt.nz/dmsdocument/27579-RHDV1-K5-Q-and-A
[92] Environmental Protection Authority (2024). Aerial 1080 use in Aotearoa New Zealand in 2023. /www.epa.govt.nz/assets/RecordsAPI/EPA-annual-report-on-aerial-1080-use-in-New-Zealand-2023.pd
[93] Morriss, G. A., Parkes, J. P., & Nugent, G. (2020). Effects of aerial 1080 operations on deer populations in New Zealand. *New Zealand Journal of Ecology*, *44*(2), 1-8. https://newzealandecology.org/nzje/3417
[94] E.g. Landcare Research. 2021. High effectiveness of deer-repellent Prodeer 1080 possum bait in the northern South Island high country. https://www.ospri.co.nz/assets/ResourcePDFs/Manaaki-Whenua-Landcare-Research-Molesworth-Report-2021.pdf
[95] Peterson, A. J. (2014). The long-term impacts of an aerial 1080 application on non-target forest species.
[96] E.g. Zero Invasive Predators. 2023. Burster 1080 to Zero Predator Elimination and South Ōkārito Spot-Treatment Operation. https://www.epa.govt.nz/assets/Uploads/Documents/Hazardous-Substances/1080-reports/1080-Operational-Reports/ZIP_Aerial-1080-Operators-Report_Burster-Elimination-and-South-Okarito-spot-treatment_November-2023.pdf

cattle,[97] and native birds such as kea,[98] karoro[99] and weka.[100] Recent proposals also include using 1080-laced baits to kill cats.[101] 1080 causes a slow and agonising death, causing vomiting, spasms and tremors over 9.5 hours on average in possums, and has been judged by animal welfare scientists to be inhumane.[102]

- Brodifacoum, an anticoagulant poison, causes animals to bleed to death over a prolonged period.[103] Like 1080, it affects non-target species, including birds and pets.[104]

Many wild animals are referred to as 'pests' in the Animal Welfare Act and only have limited protections under the Wildlife Act 1953. The use of these methods is inconsistent with the intention of the Animal Welfare Act to protect nonhuman animals, which by definition includes wildlife, from unnecessary or disproportionate harm. AJP therefore advocates for the protections that the Animal Welfare Act affords to domestic animals to be extended to all wildlife.

These animals, labelled as 'pests' in New Zealand by the Animal Welfare Act, are sentient, and did not choose to be in New Zealand, but rather are themselves the victims of past colonial actions. It is therefore both inhumane and unjust to subject them to unnecessary extreme suffering.

While AJP acknowledges the environmental challenges posed by these species, we advocate for solutions that are compassionate and effective. New technologies show great promise, such as immunocontraceptives (already used in other countries) and gene drives (the primary barrier to which is funding).[105] New Zealand must lead the way

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[97] E.g. Environmental Protection Authority. 2019. EPA releases findings on Mapara 1080 operation. https://www.epa.govt.nz/news-and-alerts/latest-news/epa-releases-findings-on-mapara-1080/

[98] E.g. Kea Conservation Trust. (2020). Monitoring threats to kea in the Matukituki Valleys, Mt Aspiring National Park https://www.keaconservation.co.nz/projects/monitoring-threats-to-kea-in-the-matukituki-valleys-mt-aspiring-national-park/

[99] E.g. Environmental Protection Authority. (2022). 2022 West Coast South Okarito Report. ttps://www.epa.govt.nz/assets/Uploads/Documents/Hazardous-Substances/1080-reports/1080-Operational-Reports/13-10-22-HSNO-compliance-report-South-Okarito.pdf

[100] E.g. Environmental Protection Authority (2024). Aerial 1080 use in Aotearoa New Zealand in 2023. /www.epa.govt.nz/assets/RecordsAPI/EPA-annual-report-on-aerial-1080-use-in-New-Zealand-2023.pd

[101] DOC (2025) New bait to control feral cats shows promise. https://www.doc.govt.nz/news/media-releases/2025-media-releases/new-bait-to-control-feral-cats-shows-promise/

[102] Eason, C., Miller, A., Ogilvie, S., & Fairweather, A. (2011). An updated review of the toxicology and ecotoxicology of sodium fluoroacetate (1080) in relation to its use as a pest control tool in New Zealand. New Zealand Journal of Ecology, 1-20.; Sherley, M. (2007). Is sodium fluoroacetate (1080) a humane poison? Animal Welfare, 16(4), 449-458.

[103] NZVA. (2016). Wild and feral mammal control. https://nzva.org.nz/positions-advocacy/position-statements/feral/

[104] Fisher, P., O'Connor, C., Wright, G., & Eason, C. T. (2004). Anticoagulant residues in rats and secondary non-target risk. DOC science internal series, 188, 29. https://www.doc.govt.nz/documents/science-and-technical/dsis188.pdf

[105] Warburton, B., Eason, C., Fisher, P., Hancox, N., Hopkins, B., Nugent, G., ... & Cowan, P. E. (2022). Alternatives for mammal pest control in New Zealand in the context of concerns about 1080 toxicant (sodium fluoroacetate). New Zealand Journal of Zoology, 49(2), 79-121.

in ethical conservation by embracing non-lethal, compassionate and scientifically supported alternatives that protect ecosystems without inflicting suffering on sentient beings.

Key Objectives

1. Ban the use of all lethal biological agents, including Rabbit Haemorrhagic Virus Disease (RHDV).
2. Cease the use of all poisons, including 1080 and Brodifacoum aerial drops.
3. Fund research into ethical, non-lethal alternatives for managing introduced species, such as:
    - Immunocontraceptives for population control
    - Fencing and habitat modification to prevent overpopulation
    - Non-toxic deterrents and repellents
4. Ensure conservation efforts align with compassionate principles and recognise the sentience and intrinsic value of all animals.

August 2025

Ending trapping and hunting for population control

AJP opposes the trapping and hunting of wild animals as a part of so-called 'pest control' activities. For AJP's policy on hunting for entertainment, see: *Hunting and Fishing policies*.

Common trapping practices include:

- Leg-Hold Traps: These devices are designed to capture animals by the limb, restraining them until they are dispatched by trappers. The use of leg-hold traps can result in severe injuries, including fractures, dislocations, and lacerations. Animals caught in these traps can experience prolonged periods of distress and pain before being euthanised.[106,107]
- Kill Traps: Intended to provide a swift death, even the most humane traps can kill non-target species or cause non-lethal injury.[108]
- Live-Capture Cage Traps: These traps aim to capture animals without immediate harm, allowing for relocation or euthanasia. Animals may experience stress, dehydration and exposure to harsh environmental conditions while confined for up to 24 hours, according to regulations. However, these regulations are not actively enforced.[109]

A lack of enforcement for existing codes of conduct means that inhumane practices persist with minimal accountability. This regulatory gap allows for the continuation of trapping and hunting methods that cause unnecessary suffering to animals.

Children and young people in New Zealand are sometimes involved in trapping activities without sufficient age restrictions.[110] This exposure raises ethical concerns regarding the normalisation of violence towards animals and potential desensitisation to animal suffering. It also poses safety risks, as handling traps and captured animals can be hazardous without proper training and supervision.

Current trapping practices, coupled with inadequate regulation and enforcement, often result in significant, and unnecessary, animal suffering. Addressing these issues

[106] Ministry for Primary Industries. (n.d.). *Restricted traps and devices*. New Zealand Government. https://www.mpi.govt.nz/animals/animal-welfare/animal-welfare-and-pest-management/traps-and-devices-used-to-manage-pests/restricted-traps-and-devices/

[107] Ministry for Primary Industries. (2011, December). *Leg-hold traps and the Animal Welfare Act 1999* [Fact sheet]. New Zealand Government. https://www.mpi.govt.nz/dmsdocument/1466-Leg-Hold-Traps-and-the-Animal-Welfare-Act-1999

[108] Ryan, E. A., Dubois, S., & Fraser, D. (2022). A Preliminary Evaluation of a Captive-bolt Trap for Commensal Rodents: Humaneness, Capture Efficiency, and Effect on Non-Target Species. *Canadian Wildlife Biology & Management (CWBM)*, *11*(2).

[109] Ministry for Primary Industries. (n.d.). *Traps and devices used to manage pests*. New Zealand Government. https://www.mpi.govt.nz/animals/animal-welfare/animal-welfare-and-pest-management/traps-and-devices-used-to-manage-pests/

[110] E.g. see https://thesavemovement.org/help-us-ban-violent-childrens-hunting-in-aotearoa-new-zealand/

requires comprehensive policy and legislative reform, including the development and implementation of more humane control methods, stricter regulations and educational initiatives to promote ethical practices in wildlife management

Key objectives

1. Amend the Animal Welfare Act to prohibit the unnecessary killing and suffering of all animals, requiring that population control be carried out with humane and non-lethal methods, and ensuring that greater accountability and stricter enforcement methods are upheld.

Interim objectives

While working toward long-term legislative change, AJP supports introducing more stringent regulations and safeguards to minimise harm to wild animals. These include:

1. **Mandatory live cameras on traps** to ensure compliance with animal welfare regulations and to facilitate immediate response once an animal is captured. Current legal requirements for trap checks every 12 hours are inadequate, and real-time monitoring would enable faster intervention to reduce suffering.
2. **Strict codes of conduct for hunting and trapping**, making ethical guidelines enforceable in legislation, rather than voluntary. AJP will advocate for uniform and legally binding standards across all hunting and trapping activities. (*aligns to Hunting and Fishing policies*)
3. **Age restrictions** to prohibit individuals under 18 from participating in trapping, hunting or any wild animal control activities that involve direct harm to animals.
4. **Stronger regulation of live trapping**, ensuring that any continued use of live traps adheres to high welfare standards, with a focus on transitioning toward non-lethal population management solutions.

August 2025

Protect and restore natural habitats

AJP supports greater protection and restoration of natural habitats and ecosystems. We recognise that the destruction or degradation of habitats and ecosystems causes direct harm to wild animals, and that both humans and wild animals are sustained by natural habitats and ecosystems.

63% of Aotearoa's land area has now been converted for human use, with animal agriculture being a primary historical cause of habitat destruction.[111] By 1930, 39% of New Zealand's land area had been cleared and transformed to make way for pastoral farming.[112] This transformation of land involved destroying forests, draining wetlands and disrupting waterways, causing significant harm to natural ecosystems and free living animals, whose habitats were obliterated or disrupted. As of 2021, this remains largely unaddressed, with 42% of land converted for farming and 8% converted for forestry.[113] In order to reverse this process, AJP would enable greater protection of native ecosystems along with the restoration of ecosystems, especially in areas currently used for animal agriculture. Pastoral farming is a highly inefficient use of land for food production,[114] using far more land compared to other crops, but producing a fraction of the calories. Moving towards a plant-based food system and away from animal agriculture would allow us to free up significant areas of land to re-wild.

Ocean and freshwater ecosystems must be protected against the destructive impacts of fishing and pollution. Industrial fishing kills vast numbers of fishes and other marine animals, disrupts marine ecosystems and destroys seafloor habitats.[115] Mining further threatens seafloor habitats and the animals that rely on them. Marine environments are heavily polluted due to plastics and microplastics,[116] oil spills,[117] and eutrophication due

[111] 'Habitat loss'. Environment Guide. (2018). https://www.environmentguide.org.nz/issues/biodiversity/key-threats/habitat-loss/
[112] Julia Haggerty and Hugh Campbell, 'Farming and the environment', Te Ara - the Encyclopedia of New Zealand, http://www.TeAra.govt.nz/en/farming-and-the-environment/print (accessed 15 February 2025)
[113] Chapter 3: Our activities and their effects. (2021, April 15). Ministry for the Environment. https://environment.govt.nz/publications/our-land-2021/chapter-3-our-activities-and-their-effects/#land-use-and-changes-in-land-use
[114] Hannah Ritchie (2021) - "If the world adopted a plant-based diet, we would reduce global agricultural land use from 4 to 1 billion hectares" Published online at OurWorldinData.org. Retrieved from: https://ourworldindata.org/land-use-diets
[115] Jennings, S., & Kaiser, M. J. (2017). The effects of fishing on marine ecosystems. ICES Journal of Marine Science, 74(9), 2283-2297; Oberle, F. K. J., Storlazzi, C. D., & Hanebuth, T. J. J. (2016). What a drag—Quantifying the global impact of chronic bottom trawling on continental shelf sediment. *Journal of Marine Systems*, 154, 243-257.
[116] IUCN. (2024). Over 460 million metric tons of plastic are produced every year for use in a wide variety of applications. An estimated 20 million metric tons of plastic litter end up in the environment every year. CN. Plastic pollution resource brief.
[117] Lovindeer, R., Mynott, S., Porobic, J., Fulton, E. A., & others. (2023). Ecosystem-level impacts of oil spills: A review of available data with confidence metrics for application to ecosystem models. *Environmental Modeling & Assessment, 28*, 939–960. https://doi.org/10.1007/s10666-023-09905-1

to farm run off and aquaculture farms.[118] These activities harm the animals living in aquatic ecosystems, and, by degrading them, in turn harm humans and animals in other ecosystems that indirectly rely on healthy oceans, rivers and lakes. These vital ecosystems must be protected and, where relevant, active steps should be taken to restore them.

In summary, AJP advocates for steps to be taken to halt further land and marine-habitat destruction, facilitate a shift towards plant-based agriculture to alleviate the impact of animal agriculture on habitats and to free up land, and will actively work to preserve and restore land and marine habitats.

Key Objectives:

1. **Restrict** further habitat destruction, of both terrestrial and aquatic ecosystems.
2. **Ban** bottom trawling
3. **Restrict** seabed mining
4. **Redirect** funds away from animal agriculture, through taxes and regulations, and towards plant-based agriculture and habitat restoration projects and practices, as outlined in our '*Introduce tighter standards and enforcement for agricultural pollution' and 'Provide financial incentives for good environmental practices' sub-policies under Objective 2 in our 'Just Transition to a Plant-Based Economy' policy*. This redirection of funds would enable:
    a. Reserves: Stronger protection of, and creation of more, land and marine reserves (including more Highly Protected Marine Areas)
    b. Restoration: Roll out restoration projects to restore habitats, including mangroves, peat bogs, forests, marine habitats and other natural ecosystems. Subsidise farmers and landowners actively restoring the land and associated ecosystems.
    c. Subsidise green community projects
    d. Create wildlife corridors (link to Objective 3: *Protect Wildlife From Anthropogenic Harms*)
5. **Implement** educational programmes in schools, universities, and communities to promote awareness of the importance of living within our ecological limits, for the purpose of avoiding, remedying and mitigating the destruction of natural environments in which animals live. *See Compassionate Education policy.*

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[118] Wang, W. F. (2024). Eutrophication mechanisms and their impacts on coastal marine ecosystems. International Journal of Marine Science, 14(4), 285–294. https://doi.org/10.5376/ijms.2024.14.0032

Protect wildlife from anthropogenic harms

Wild animals are frequently harmed due to the design of urban structures, roads, and the activities of people who are often unaware of their impacts. To address these issues, AJP wishes to see greater integration of wildlife considerations into urban planning, road design and signage by way of impact assessments. This would require greater collaboration between local councils, urban planners, conservation groups and communities to develop wildlife-friendly infrastructure.

Many wild animals, native and introduced, inhabit towns and cities and are frequently harmed by their human-centric design. For example, windows can be made with glass that is more visible to birds, thereby reducing collisions.[119] Human-wildlife conflicts can be addressed in nonviolent ways, such as through nonviolent population control of pigeons, rather than using spikes to restrict perching.[120] Generally speaking, by considering animals in the design of urban structures and areas, harms to wild animals can be reduced or avoided altogether. This may often require collaboration between local councils, urban planners, conservation groups and communities.

This is particularly important in the design of roads, which frequently kill and injure wild animals. Measures such as wildlife crossings, barriers, and lower speed limits can reduce these harms,[121] and research into wildlife movement patterns can inform road and urban planning that prioritises animal safety. While the *Wildlife Act 1953* requires permits for developments that may disturb or kill protected species, its focus remains on species conservation and habitat protection rather than the welfare of individual animals, leaving a gap between conservation law and animal welfare.

An important aspect of making urban areas friendly to wild animals is by the integration of habitat. This may involve planting native species, connecting fragmented habitats through wildlife corridors, or creating green roofs and pocket parks. Such measures not only provide shelter and food for animals but also improve the quality of life for people.

Lastly, signs warning people of sensitive wildlife, or educating people about how to behave around them, need to be informative, highly visible, and strategically placed to maximise their effectiveness in both rural and urban areas.

Key Objectives

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[119] American Bird Conservancy. (2024). *Bird-smart glass testing program*. https://abcbirds.org/glass-collisions/testing/

[120] Animal Aid. (2024, November 8). The case for the humane control of pigeons. https://www.animalaid.org.uk/case-humane-control-pigeons/; Animal Welfare Institute. (2014, Winter). Bird birth control: Effective, but underutilized management tool. *AWI Quarterly*. https://awionline.org/awi-quarterly/2014-winter/bird-birth-control-effective-underutilized-management-tool

[121] See e.g. Rytwinski, T., Soanes, K., Jaeger, J. A. G., Fahrig, L., Findlay, C. S., Houlahan, J., van der Ree, R., & van der Grift, E. A. (2016). How effective is road mitigation at reducing road-kill? A meta-analysis. *PLOS ONE, 11*(11), e0166941. https://doi.org/10.1371/journal.pone.0166941

1. Require animal welfare impact assessments to be carried out in the design of all roading and urban development projects. Enact stricter regulations mandating designs that better protect wild animals, especially where they are particularly vulnerable.
2. Raise awareness of impacts on wild animals through education and public engagement, encouraging more compassionate wildlife-friendly behaviour and fostering community-led conservation efforts.
3. Promote rewilding projects in urban areas, using native species where possible, and the connection of existing habitats through wildlife corridors.
4. Fund scientific research to better understand the impacts of roads and urban structures on wild animals, and the development of solutions to mitigate these impacts.

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Mitigate natural threats to wild animals

AJP recognises that wild animals often suffer from causes of natural origin. In many cases, intervention can be appropriate to protect wild animals from threats that they are not able to cope with.

There are many examples today of people and conservation agencies intervening to protect particularly endangered or charismatic species. For example, stranded whales or dolphins are often kept wet and efforts are made to refloat them;[122] lost penguins are transported back to Antarctica;[123] underweight yellow-eyed penguin/hoihoi chicks have been hand-reared until they can survive at sea;[124] and following cyclone Gabrielle, wildlife stranded in mud and floodwaters were rescued.[125] However, non-threatened and less charismatic species often suffer from similar threats. AJP wishes to see these existing efforts increased and expanded to other species. Research is also needed to understand the welfare of wild animals and how their flourishing can be ensured and legally protected.

Wild animal populations are especially impacted by natural disasters. For example, the Kaikōura earthquake disrupted marine ecosystems and seal colonies,[126] while increasingly frequent severe storms and flooding events have destroyed habitats and nesting sites of birds like the endangered wrybill.[127] Prolonged drought conditions have reduced food availability for many species,[128] and rising sea levels threaten coastal wildlife.[129] The increasing intensity of these events due to climate change compounds the suffering of wild animals who have no means to escape these disasters.

Wild animals also suffer frequently from less cataclysmic events. Many suffer from starvation, disease, harsh weather, or threats from other species or members of their

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[122] Department of Conservation. (2015). *Stranded whales and dolphins: How you can help*. Wellington, NZ: DOC. https://www.doc.govt.nz/documents/conservation/native-animals/marine-mammals/stranded-whales-dolphins.pdf
[123] National Institute of Water & Atmospheric Research (NIWA). (2011, September 4). *Goodbye Happy Feet – We wish you well* (release into Southern Ocean near Campbell Island from RV Tangaroa). https://niwa.co.nz/news/goodbye-happy-feet-we-wish-you-well
[124] Alden, B. (2016). *Summary of research funded in 2016: Supplementary feeding and post-fledging dispersal of hoiho/yellow-eyed penguins*. Birds New Zealand Research Fund. Retrieved from https://www.birdsnz.org.nz/wp-content/uploads/2019/02/1805-Summary-Article-YEP-Fledgling-Dispersal.pdf
[125] IFAW. (2023). *Animals rescued from New Zealand cyclone wreckage* [Press release]. International Fund for Animal Welfare. Retrieved from https://www.ifaw.org/press-releases/animal-rescue-nz-cyclone
[126] Schiel, D. R., Alestra, T., Gerrity, S., Orchard, S., Dunmore, R., Pirker, J., Lilley, S., & Tait, L. (2019). *The Kaikōura earthquake in southern New Zealand: Loss of connectivity of marine communities and the necessity of a cross-ecosystem perspective*. Aquatic Conservation: Marine and Freshwater Ecosystems, 29(9), 1520–1534. https://doi.org/10.1002/aqc.3122
[127] Dowding, J. E., et al. (2020). *Survival and breeding success of wrybills (Anarhynchus frontalis) in the Tekapo and Tasman Rivers, South Canterbury, New Zealand*. Notornis, 67, 755–764.
[128] Department of Conservation. (n.d.). *Climate change impacts on our native wildlife*. https://www.doc.govt.nz/our-work/climate-change-and-conservation/climate-change-impacts-on-our-native-wildlife/
[129] Ministry for the Environment. (2023). *Our atmosphere and climate 2023: Outlooks*. https://environment.govt.nz/publications/our-atmosphere-and-climate-2023/outlooks/

own species.[130] While these threats are more challenging to address without disrupting ecosystems, the development of wild animal welfare science[131] will help us to understand these problems and may lead to better ways to promote the flourishing, and protection, of wild animals in the future.

AJP is committed to developing a comprehensive approach to protecting all wild animals from natural threats. We will encourage interventions during natural disasters, promote scientific research into wild animal welfare, and support volunteer rescue groups. Our policy aims to expand protection beyond endangered species to include all animals affected by natural threats, while establishing a national research institute dedicated to understanding and improving the lives of wild animals throughout Aotearoa.

Key Objectives:

1. Promote wild animal welfare science to better understand the lives of wild animals and how their flourishing and protection can be promoted.
2. Redefine the functions of the Ministry of the Environment to include the promotion of wild animal welfare.
3. Encourage other government and community agencies and local councils to consider the impacts of their policies on wild animal welfare where appropriate.

Interim measures

4. Establish protocols in local councils and environmental bodies for interventions to protect wild animals in the event of natural disasters.
5. Support volunteer groups that protect wild animals from natural threats.
6. Increase interventions to protect endangered species from natural threats.
7. Establishment of a national research institute for the study of wild animal welfare and the design and implementation of impact assessments and protection strategies.

[130] Horta, O. (2017). Animal suffering in nature: The case for intervention. *Environmental Ethics*, *39*(3), 261-279.
[131] For a definition and explanation of wild animal welfare science, see https://www.wildanimalinitiative.org/research-priorities#introduction

Cats, Conservation and Better Solutions

Policy Position developed from AJP policies: Why the Animal Justice Party opposes Predator Free 2050's inclusion of 'feral' cats

The Government has recently added 'feral'[132] cats to the Predator Free 2050 target species list. We oppose this. Not because we are indifferent to native wildlife, but because we believe the framing behind this decision is wrong, the actions and methods it encourages are cruel, and the evidence for its effectiveness in strengthening indigenous biodiversity is weaker than its proponents claim.

This is not a single-issue position. It reflects a consistent set of values that run across our entire policy platform: that all animals matter, that killing is not synonymous with conservation, and that Aotearoa can do better.

Furthermore, cats are Aotearoa's most beloved companion animal. The lives of many are enriched by being 'cat guardians' - especially those who are socially marginalised. The health and social benefits of cat guardianship are widely recognised. Aotearoa New Zealand has one of the world's highest rates of cat ownership, with 40% of all households sharing their homes with a companion cat.[133] The cultural affection which so many have for this species extends beyond the cat-guardian bond to encompass stray/community cats - there are well over 300 independent shelters and rescue groups across the motu[134] dedicated to rescue, rehabilitation and re-homing, as well as many more individuals who care for neighbourhood stray/community cats or managed desexed colonies, and very little social license even among the general public for the lethal management of unowned cats.

Three categories of cat were defined in the Companion Cat Code under the Animal Welfare Act,[135] and these definitions are accepted and used by DOC. These are:

- companion cats:
- community or stray cats (the term community has been widely adopted in recognition that these cats have their needs met by the collective community):

[132] Note on Terminology: While we acknowledge the definitions of companion, stray, and feral cats outlined in the Code of Welfare: Companion Cats, we intentionally reject the term 'feral' due to its embedded connotations of pestilence and aggression. Following modern animal relations frameworks (such as Donaldson and Kymlicka's Zoopolis), we prefer the term 'wild-living'. This distinction shifts the focus from a damaging biological label to a neutral observation of their lifestyle, recognising that these cats simply live independently outside human domestic society.

[133] New Zealand's unbreakable bond with pets: Insights from the latest Companion Animals NZ Report

[134] Shelter Register Aotearoa — Companion Animals New Zealand

[135] Code of Welfare: Companion Cats | NZ Government

- feral cats:

Of these, only ‘feral’ cats were added to the PF2050 target list. The overwhelming majority of companion and community cats by definition live in cities and towns, where biodiversity values are negatively impacted by a suite of factors - inadequate and fragmented habitat, disturbance, constructed barriers and impervious surfaces, lights, reflective surfaces, widespread chemical use, traffic, etc, and therefore the potential of companion and community cats to impact on biodiversity values is low. And these cats are fed - only a small proportion of cats hunt effectively when they do not need to do so to survive, and in cities and towns available prey is not as likely to include taonga species nor is it likely to occur at a level which threatens the survival of these species.

Our position at a glance

We support a greater focus on the introduction of science-based, ethical methods to manage the genuine tension between introduced species, including cats, and indigenous species. We believe the primary driver of indigenous species decline in Aotearoa is habitat loss, not introduced animals, and that this must be honestly named and addressed proportionately.

What we believe: six policy pillars

1. **All animals matter**

Both indigenous and introduced species are sentient beings with a right to live unimpeded by human activities. Cats did not choose to come here. Humans brought them.

2. **Language shapes thinking**

We call for an end to unscientific, emotive and dehumanising terms to describe introduced animals that are not useful to us. Language that vilifies animals makes killing them easier to ignore. NZ has no hate speech laws pertaining specifically to animals - while animals cannot be hurt directly by the attribution of malice or intentional damage achieved by use of terms like ‘pest’, ‘invasive’, ‘stone-cold killer’, ‘utter killing machines’,‘killers for fun’, the effect is to demonise and to make killing and cruelty more acceptable.

3. **Lethal eradication is not conservation**

We oppose the use of 1080 poison on cats. Animal welfare scientists have found 1080 causes deaths averaging 9.5 hours of spasms and tremors. This is not humane. It is not acceptable.

4. **Innovation over violence**

Immunocontraceptives, in-ovo sex determination, gene drives are real, proven or emerging solutions. We question the belief that pre-human ecologies can/should be restored right across present day Aotearoa with its permanent and growing population and large scale agricultural economy, and that mainland eradication of introduced predator and perhaps also competitor species is achievable using available and even foreseeable technologies. We support a focus on strengthening and augmenting an adequately sized, world class reserve system encompassing multiple habitats above an unrealistic, overly-diffuse and 'ad infinitum' policy of eradication.

5. **Address the real driver**

Habitat loss is the primary driver of native species decline in Aotearoa. Focusing on introduced animals distracts from the human activities most responsible for ecological harm.

6. **Accountability and transparency**

An independent Commissioner for Animals and mandatory live cameras on traps would ensure that animal welfare decisions are made free from commercial or political pressure.

What we are calling for

Immediate steps

- A halt to any programme using 1080 poison or lethal trapping to kill cats under the Predator Free 2050 framework
- An immediate ban on recreational hunting of cats
- Mandatory live cameras on all traps used in conservation operations, to ensure real-time monitoring and accountability

Medium-term investment

- Government funding for research into immunocontraceptive programmes for free-living cats, building on models already used in other countries
- Expansion of desexing programmes, including government-subsidised or free desexing for low-income households, to reduce the number of cats entering the feral population in the first place
- Habitat fencing and ecosystem restoration as the primary tool for protecting vulnerable native species

Structural reform

- An independent Commissioner for Animals with genuine investigative powers, to ensure conservation decisions are made free from commercial or political influence
- Amendment of the Animal Welfare Act to extend protections to all wildlife, including introduced species, so that no animal can be subjected to extreme suffering for conservation purposes
- A shift in public funding away from lethal control and toward non-violent population management and habitat restoration

A note on complexity

We recognise there is a genuine tension here. Native species in Aotearoa evolved without land-based predators, and introduced animals do cause real harm. We do not dismiss that. But we do not accept that the only available response is mass killing. The choice is not between doing nothing and eradication. There is a third path, and this party exists to push for it.

We also recognise that many of the people who work in conservation care deeply about all animals. We want to work with them, not against them. The disagreement is about methods, not motivation.

Aotearoa can be a compassionate nation for all its animals, native and introduced alike. That is not a compromise. It is a higher standard.

July 2026

Legislation and Regulation Reform for Animal Protection

AJP supports legislation and regulation that prioritises the well-being, protection and rights of animals as sentient beings, ensuring they are not subjected to exploitation, harm or cruelty. It is imperative that animal welfare and protection legislation is adequately resourced and equipped with robust compliance monitoring, appropriate penalties and regulatory enforcement capabilities.

Animal welfare legislation should be drafted with the sole intention of recognising animal sentience and protecting animals, without influence from industries that profit from their exploitation. The principles enshrined in the Animal Welfare Act 1999 must be enforceable, without loopholes that allow industries to evade responsibility by self-regulation. Until adequate animal protection legislation is in place, AJP will also campaign to remove and prohibit exemptions and inconsistencies that allow animal cruelty to occur (for example, codes of practice for the “welfare” of farmed animals).

AJP supports a legal framework that reflects a societal commitment to valuing, protecting and respecting animals, fostering responsible and compassionate treatment in all contexts and industries. Without stringent, and enforceable, legal protection, animals remain vulnerable to cruelty and exploitation, their welfare jeopardised by profit-driven motives.

Empowering and resourcing authorities to share information and enforce legislation and regulations is essential, ensuring individuals and organisations are held accountable for infringements. Championing animal-centric legislation paves the way to a more just and humane society where positive animal welfare[136] is legally recognised and animals are granted by the law the dignity and protection they deserve.

[136] A scientific network entitled ‘Laying the foundations for positive animal welfare’ has been established to advance its scientific understanding (https://LIFTanimalwelfare.eu/). This network comprises more than 330 scientists from 42 countries. The resulting definition is “Positive animal welfare is defined as the animal flourishing through the experience of predominantly positive mental states and the development of competence and resilience” https://royalsocietypublishing.org/doi/epdf/10.1098/rsbl.2024.0382.

Animal welfare has become a global concern, which first requires adequate regulation at a national level.

There is an urgent need to overhaul New Zealand's animal welfare governance system to enable a paradigm shift in the value of animals and human responsibility towards them.[137] It is crucial that improved animal welfare and protection is prioritised by legislative reform and strengthened regulatory enforcement to avoid ongoing exploitation and harm at human hands.

A Kantar Poll conducted nationwide in April 2023 showed that the welfare or treatment of animals is extremely, or very, important to three in four New Zealanders.[138]

A Horizon Research poll conducted nationwide in June 2023 shows that 90% of New Zealanders believe it is important to protect the welfare of animals farmed in New Zealand and 71% agree that the Government should do more to promote greater awareness of farmed animal welfare internationally.[139]

Purpose and Objectives of the Animal Protection Policy

AJP advocates for a new legal framework that recognises animals' right to live without suffering harm from humans and ensures that their lives and well-being are protected by the advancement of New Zealand's legal system.

The core purpose of the animal protection policy is:

- To safeguard the welfare and well-being of animals
- To promote humane treatment of animals in all sectors (agriculture, entertainment, research, etc.)
- To reduce instances of animal cruelty, neglect, and exploitation
- To foster public awareness and ethical responsibility regarding animal rights
- To protect endangered species and their habitats

AJP opposes all exploitation of animals and advocates for their ethical treatment in all human-animal interactions. We stand against all practices that subject animals to stress

[137] Despite often being lauded as a leader in animal welfare and protection, New Zealand has a very low ranking in global animal welfare indices: https://api.worldanimalprotection.org/country/new-zealand
[138] https://www.scoop.co.nz/stories/PO2309/S00145/political-parties-neglect-animal-welfare-survey-reveals.htm
[139] https://www.horizonpoll.co.nz/page/675/80-say-impo_

and/or harm. Our vision is for a society that places value on the well-being of animals and prohibits all practices that exploit or harm them.

Our advocacy entails the development and promotion of policies that end harmful practices and legally protect animals. Holistically, AJP policies promote a vision of a world where animals can thrive in ways that respect their inherent needs and behaviours.

Key Objectives

1. Appoint a dedicated Commissioner for Animals, responsible for overseeing the implementation, monitoring and enforcement of animal welfare and protection laws, to coordinate and lead animal protection efforts (see separate policy *Commissioner for Animals)*.
2. Abolish the classification of animals as property and introduce consistent legislation that defines and acknowledges animal sentience, ensuring legal protection from harm
3. While uniform animal protection laws are being developed, campaign for the removal and prohibition of exemptions or ambiguities that enable cruelty to animals, such as Codes of Practice for the supposed “welfare” of farmed animals
4. Promote collaboration between law enforcement agencies to combat animal abuse and its links to interpersonal violence.
5. Apply import or sales restrictions on animal products sourced from outside New Zealand that do not meet the farmed animal welfare standards applied to domestic production.[140]
6. Advocate for the creation and implementation of an international treaty on animal rights

January 2025

[140] Animal Policy International (2024). Closing the Welfare Gap: Why New Zealand Must Apply Its Animal Protection Standards to Imports

Legislative Foundations

To create a comprehensive and effective Animal Protection Policy, a new legislative framework must be established. This framework should address animal welfare, conservation, ethical treatment, and the enforcement of laws to ensure that animals are protected from cruelty and exploitation. Below is a proposed structure for legislative foundations that could guide the formulation of such a policy:

1. Define animal sentience in legislation
2. Strengthen legal protections recognising animals as sentient beings
3. Propose a new legislative framework with positive welfare obligations
4. Constitutional rights for nature: advocate for legal personhood for ecosystems and species
5. Abolish the legal classification of animals as property and grant animals legal rights

This will be achieved through dialogue, research, analysis and solutions-based reform proposals to inform legislative and policy change and to enable greater political accountability and more inclusive and just governance.

Law and policy reforms will be secured to create an animal welfare governance system that is transparent, in line with contemporary science and public expectations, and focuses on the wellbeing and protection of animals. These reforms in New Zealand will have the potential to set a precedent for the creation of large-scale change globally.

Sentience

The acknowledgement of animals as sentient in an amendment to the Animal Welfare Act 1999 (the "Act") in 2015 was the first of its kind in a common law jurisdiction. However, its location in the long title is telling – it simply states what the Act is about and is not defined or incorporated into the offence sections. The New Zealand Government has openly stated it is a "symbolic" change only and creates no legal or enforceable responsibility.[141]

Property

[141] M.B. R. Ferrere, *The (Symbolic) Legislative Recognition of Animal Sentience*, 28 Animal L. Rev. 117 (2022). Available at: https://lawcommons.lclark.edu/alr/vol28/iss1/6

Domestic and wild animals are extremely vulnerable members of New Zealand society, and therefore require stringent legal protection. They are entitled to the same level of protection and rights under the law as humans and it is the antithesis of social justice that their vulnerability is not adequately legally protected.

Currently classed as the property of humans, animals have no legal rights, and therefore require AJP's advocacy, to ensure that they receive the full protection of the law.

Interim measures, while we work towards legislative change, include:

- Communication with politicians to secure reform commitments, writing submissions and reports to Select Committees, the National Animal Welfare Advisory Committee (NAWAC) and the National Animal Ethics Advisory Committee (NAEAC) on Acts, Regulations, Codes of Animal Welfare and other laws and policies affecting animals
- Reviewing current animal welfare laws and providing proposals to ensure modern animal welfare policies and legislation, using available "best practice" models, and internationally appropriate precedents as guidance
- Drafting national strategies, regulations and/or codes of practice as necessary
- Developing deterrent penalties and more effective enforcement systems
- Developing educational materials for politicians and the public

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Regulatory Oversight and Enforcement

AJP believes that animal welfare and protection is a social justice issue intrinsically linked to other areas where the vulnerable are exploited, for example, human rights, labour rights and environmental justice.

There are several Commissions and Commissioners in New Zealand dedicated to improving these societal issues, such as the Human Rights Commission, the Climate Change Commission and the Children's Commissioner. They provide independent information and recommendations to the Government.

Currently the regulation of the welfare of animals is the responsibility of the Minister of Primary Industries and the Minister of Agriculture. New Zealand does not have a Commissioner for Animals who is independent to the Government and who can advocate independently on animal welfare and protection issues.

Many New Zealanders have already expressed their desire to see the establishment of a Commissioner for Animals to advance the welfare needs and legal protection of animals.[142]

It is envisaged that the Commissioner will have legal jurisdiction over animal wellbeing and protection, undertake monitoring of all sectors, and have the authority to undertake comprehensive reviews of, and propose changes to, legislation and the enforcement mechanisms of the current legal system, working to repeal and amend any Codes of Welfare that contradict the Animal Welfare Act 1999.

Below is a proposed structure for regulatory oversight and enforcement that could guide the formulation of such a policy:

1. Reform the National Animal Welfare Advisory Committee
2. Legislative reform that prohibits inhumane farming practices and establishes a more robust monitoring and enforcement system in all animal farming operations, including:
    - Regular MPI inspections
    - Specialised training for animal protection officers
    - Journey documentation requirements

[142] https://commissionerforanimals.nz/

- Mandatory incident reporting
- Increased penalties for violations
- Public reporting

3. Establish a Commissioner for Animals to:
   - Oversee administration and enforcement of animal protection legislation
   - Provide national leadership on animal protection
   - Undertake a comprehensive review of the enforcement provisions and penalties of the Act and recommend improved deterrence measures that better protect animals
   - Undertake a comprehensive review of the Codes of Welfare
   - Update the national animal welfare strategy (created in 2013)
   - See separate policy *Commissioner for Animals*
4. Establish a specialised animal welfare unit within the New Zealand Police, removing prosecution and enforcement responsibilities from the SPCA New Zealand [143]

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[143] https://www.scoop.co.nz/stories/AK2502/S00726/study-reveals-flaws-in-animal-protection-laws.htm

International Considerations

The shift in the international animal welfare and protection policy environment highlights the growing recognition of animal welfare as a critical issue on the global stage.

It is no longer viewed as peripheral but has become integral to discussions in regional and international policy forums.

This change is underscored by the emergence of an expanding framework of science-based standards, conventions, treaties, regulations, directives, and agreements.

Key trends in this evolving landscape include:

1. **Science-Based Frameworks:** Policy decisions are increasingly guided by robust scientific research, which ensures that animal welfare measures are grounded in evidence and best practices.
2. **Global and Regional Agreements:** International treaties and regional directives, such as the Convention on International Trade in Endangered Species of Wild Fauna and Flora (CITES), the World Organisation for Animal Health (WOAH) standards or EU directives on animal welfare, set benchmarks for practices across borders.
3. **Integration into Broader Agendas:** Animal welfare is being linked with sustainability, public health, biodiversity, and climate change, ensuring it receives attention in broader policy contexts.
4. **Stakeholder Collaboration:** Governments, NGOs, scientists, and industry players are collaborating more actively to develop and implement welfare policies.

This evolving framework not only reflects a growing ethical commitment to animals but also acknowledges their role in sustainable development and human wellbeing. Global animal protection is, however, a complex challenge requiring collaboration across countries, cultures, and legal systems.

While there are various treaties, conventions, and agreements addressing specific aspects of animal welfare, there is no unified international instrument that broadly regulates animal welfare across all contexts and provides holistic animal welfare protections.

Key gaps include:

1. **Limited Scope**: Existing frameworks often prioritise conservation and biodiversity rather than the welfare of individual animals. This leaves many species, especially those not endangered or economically significant, without legal protection.
2. **Lack of Universal Standards and Jurisdictional Issues**: Countries have varying cultural, economic, and ethical views on animal welfare, making it difficult to establish universally accepted standards. International frameworks may conflict with national sovereignty, limiting their enforceability within domestic legal systems.
3. **Non-Binding Nature**: Many international standards, such as the WOAH's animal welfare standards, are non-binding, leaving adoption and enforcement at the discretion of individual nations.
4. **Lack of Enforceability**: Even binding agreements like CITES face challenges with enforcement, as they rely on national governments to implement and monitor compliance.
5. **Species-Specific Gaps**: Many frameworks focus on specific species or groups (e.g., endangered species under CITES), leaving gaps in protection for other animals, such as farmed or laboratory animals, despite these being the largest groups of animals directly impacted by human activity.

Below is a proposed structure to guide the formulation of a policy to advocate for more comprehensive and enforceable global animal protection frameworks:

1. **Review of International Trade Law**: Review New Zealand's international trade law and policy instruments and challenge any provisions that undermine animal protection.
2. **Harmonising Standards**: Creating internationally accepted benchmarks that accommodate regional differences whilst maintaining high welfare standards for imported animal products. As New Zealand has some of the most robust animal welfare practices, compared to our trading partners, we have set the benchmark for our primary industry and a framework for continuous improvement in animal quality of life:
    - AJP will campaign for uniform standards when importing animal products.

- AJP will continue to advocate for discussions with trading partners to improve practices or find alternative suppliers.
- AJP will continue to push for a fairer and more equitable system.
- AJP will use this issue as a global platform to advocate for animals used for agriculture.

3. **Developing Binding Agreements**: Evaluate international conventions and agreements, advocate for an international treaty on animal rights, and support a transition from voluntary guidelines to binding treaties with clear accountability mechanisms.
4. **Promoting Education and Advocacy**: Building public awareness and fostering a cultural shift toward valuing animal welfare globally.

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Commissioner for Animals

The Animal Justice Party Aotearoa NZ (AJP) believes that all animals in Aotearoa deserve adequate representation in Parliament, to ensure they are protected from exploitation and mistreatment.

To strengthen the voice of animals, we are advocating for the independent position of Commissioner for Animals to be established. Animal welfare is currently regulated by the Ministry for Primary Industries (MPI). This is the same Government department responsible for seizing export opportunities and overseeing agriculture productivity[144]. Decisions on animal welfare policies are being driven by industry stakeholders who are invested in profiting from the use of animals.

We believe this is detrimental to the rights and welfare of animals, as there is a clear conflict of interest, resulting in inadequate standards and an inability for animal welfare to be the primary concern in many areas.

Key Objectives.

1. Appoint an independent Commissioner for Animals who will have the authority to undertake a comprehensive review of the current system, and provide national leadership on animal protection.
2. Ensure adequate funding towards research and policy making that will improve animal well-being as backed by science.
3. Propose that the Commissioner for Animals has the power to hold MPI and other stakeholders accountable for the effective administration of the Animal Welfare Act 1999.
4. Ensure the Commissioner for Animals maintains independence from the executive Government to prevent conflicts of interest.
5. Ensure the Commissioner for Animals is equipped to make recommendations to improve enforcement of the Animal Welfare Act 1999 and to increase or add penalties where these are considered necessary.
6. Ensure adequate resources are appointed to organizations such as MPI and RNZSPCA to allow them to enforce the Animal Welfare Act 1999.
7. Ensure that the Ministry for Primary Industries updates the national Animal Welfare Strategy '2013'[145], and these updates include strenuous positive protections to be enacted.

[144] MPI stats
[145] Animal Welfare Strategy

Animal welfare standards and known breaches

The Animal Welfare Act 1999[146] outlines the needs of animals as follows:

- Proper and sufficient food and water.
- Adequate shelter.
- The opportunity to display normal patterns of behaviour.
- Physical handling in a manner which minimises the likelihood of unreasonable or unnecessary pain or distress.
- Protection from, and rapid diagnosis of, any significant injury or disease.

These basic needs must be met by law and oftentimes they are not[147], hence the need for such a position as the Commissioner for Animals to be established. An independent Commissioner for Animals should be equipped to propose changes to legislation and enforcement where these basic requirements are being ignored or compromised.

Why do we need the Commissioner for Animals to be established?

New Zealand is the second largest exporter of animal products globally[148], and while our Animal Welfare Act may seem adequate, the accompanying Codes, shaped by the animal agriculture industry, at times directly breach this Act. Because Aotearoa has such a large export industry, it is crucial that ethics and standards are upheld. As This industry is governed by stakeholders who do not have an impartial interest[149], the rights and welfare of animals is often not prioritised. Simple things like the right to adequate shelter are being ignored and animals are suffering as a result[150]. New Zealand promotes animal welfare as our 'brand image' and prioritises animal welfare as part of our export story. It would seem that we are only capable of improving welfare standards

as a part of our export image but while there are animals being housed inappropriately, enduring inadequate shade and shelter, and being denied basic freedoms, we can not claim this image as truth[151]. The Commissioner for Animals would ensure a better outcome for all animals including farmed animals, animals in entertainment, companion animals, wild animals, and animals in research, testing and teaching.

[146] Animal Welfare Act Ref
[147] Proof
[148] Global export stats
[149] Research about subpar standards
[150] Proof of inadequate housing and standard of care.
[151] Safe or SPCA link

Key legislative changes and priority issues for the Commissioner for Animals to address:

AJP will work towards legislation to repeal any codes of welfare that conflict with the requirements of the Animal Welfare Act 1999. The changes to legislation will be the framework the Commissioner for Animals utilises to ensure proper practices are enacted in animal spaces, such as animal agriculture and animals used for entertainment purposes. Along with multiple other organisations such as Save Animals From Exploitation 'SAFE'[152], Royal New Zealand Society for the Prevention of Cruelty to Animals Incorporated 'RNZSPCA'[153], the New Zealand Animal Law Association 'NZALA'[154], Helping You Help Animals 'HUHA'[155], and the New Zealand Anti-Vivisection Society 'NZAVS'[156]; AJP firmly believes an independent commissioner who is solely responsible for improving the lives of animals, will help to create a future where animals are no longer being exploited or harmed. Animals should be allocated the right to no longer be viewed as commodities or property. As living, sentient beings they deserve protection and conservation.

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NZAVS Supports the Call for a Commissioner for Animals
NZALA to release a report into inconsistencies between the Codes and the Act
New Zealand Animal Law Conference 2019
NZALA_Farmed_Animal_Report
New Zealand Animal Welfare Strategy, Ministry for Primary Industries
https://www.mpi.govt.nz/dmsdocument/3963-Animal-Welfare-Matters-New-Zealand-Animal-Welfare-Strategy

Commissioner for Animals Policy, created September 2023, updated April 2025

[152] SAFE
[153] SPCA
[154] NZALA
[155] HUHA
[156] NZAVS

End the Private Sale and Use of Fireworks

The Animal Justice Party NZ (AJP) will end the private sale and use of fireworks.

Fireworks cause preventable environmental damage, wildlife harm and animal distress across Aotearoa.[157] The science is clear, and the public demand for change is overwhelming.[158] [159] This policy addresses the urgent need to protect our marine ecosystems, wildlife and companion animals from the harmful effects of explosive celebrations.[160]

The private use of fireworks in residential areas and sensitive environments creates unnecessary suffering and environmental contamination that is entirely preventable.[161] By ending private fireworks sales and use, we can eliminate the majority of fireworks-related harm while transitioning to sustainable and animal friendly celebration alternatives.[162]

Environmental Impact

Fireworks release toxic heavy metals including barium, strontium, aluminium, and copper directly into our environment. These pollutants contaminate sand, groundwater, and marine systems, with particular concern for coastal areas where debris enters the ocean with each tide.[163] [164] Research demonstrates that fireworks cause significant

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[157] Bateman, P. W., Gilson, L. N., & Bradshaw, P. (2023). Not just a flash in the pan: Short- and long-term impacts of fireworks on the environment. *Pacific Conservation Biology, 29*(5), 396–401. https://doi.org/10.1071/PC22040

[158] Sapien. (2024, August). *Research conducted for the Pawprint Petition.* Retrieved from https://www.animates.co.nz/pawprint-petition

[159] Auckland Council. (2020, October 21). *Briefing to incoming minister: Fireworks.* https://ourauckland.aucklandcouncil.govt.nz/media/pgdb4emk/20201021_briefing-to-incoming-minister_fireworks.pdf

[160] Han, J. (2024, December 30). Crowd-pleasing fireworks are not so pleasing to the planet. *Earth.Org.* https://earth.org/environmental-impact-of-fireworks/

[161] L'Éthiquerie. (2025, April 16). *Why are fireworks harmful to wild animals and what can replace them?* Faunalytics. https://faunalytics.org/why-are-fireworks-harmful-to-wild-animals-and-what-can-replace-them/

[162] The Royal New Zealand Society for the Prevention of Cruelty to Animals. (2025, September 1). *Submission on the petitions of Animates NZ, Raewyn Harrison, and Suzanne Cook: Requesting a ban on the private sale and use of fireworks* [Submission]. https://www.spca.nz/images/assets/1171547/1/rnzspca%203%20x%20fireworks%20petitions%20submission%20final.pdf

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[164] Probert, T. S., van Aarde, R. M., Bester, M., & Kotschy, K. (2024). *Case study assessing the short-term impacts of fireworks on marine species*. Cape of Good Hope SPCA. https://capespca.co.za/wp-content/uploads/2024/03/Probert-et-al.-2024.-Case-study-assessing-the-short-term-impacts-of-fireworks-on-marine-species.pdf

spikes in air and water pollution, including harmful fine particulate matter (PM2.5), perchlorates, and nitrogen oxides.[165] Perchlorates interfere with thyroid function in both animals and humans and persist in waterways and drinking water supplies.[166]

Wildlife Harm

Fireworks displays fundamentally contradict the conservation purpose of New Zealand's core environmental legislation, including the *Wildlife Act 1953*, the *Marine Mammals Protection Act 1978*, and the *Fisheries Act 1996*, by introducing noise, chemical pollution and acute stress that compromises the well-being and habitat of legally protected seabirds and marine mammals.

Many of these species are classified as threatened under the New Zealand Threat Classification System and the IUCN Red List.[167]

International studies, utilising radar and GPS tracking, consistently show that fireworks cause mass panic flights in birds, often at night when they would otherwise be resting. These disturbances can increase flight activity a thousand-fold and force birds to fly for over an hour at unusually high altitudes, expending significant energy needed for survival and breeding.[168] [169] [170]

The consequences are particularly severe for nesting birds. In New Zealand, the sale period for Guy Fawkes (November 2–5) directly coincides with the peak breeding and nesting season for many native species. This timing dramatically increases the risk of adverse long-term population effects, including nest abandonment, increased predation on exposed eggs and chicks when adult birds are startled off the nest, and fatal

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[165] Sijimol, M. R., & Mohan, M. (2014). Environmental impacts of perchlorate with special reference to fireworks—A review. *Environmental Monitoring and Assessment*, *186*(11), 7203–7210. https://doi.org/10.1007/s10661-014-3921-4

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[170] **Hoekstra, B., Bouten, W., Dokter, A., van Gasteren, H., van Turnhout, C., Kranstauber, B., van Loon, E., Leijnse, H., & Shamoun-Baranes, J.** (2023). Fireworks disturbance across bird communities. *Frontiers in Ecology and the Environment*, *22*(1), 74–79. https://doi.org/10.1002/fee.2694

collisions with obstacles during panicked night flights. Common urban birds also show reduced fledgling numbers when exposed to fireworks during breeding season.[171] Even outside nesting season, birds experience fright responses that waste critical energy during winter and interrupt essential feeding patterns.[172]

Companion and Farmed Animal Welfare

Loud, unpredictable explosions trigger fear, panic and behaviours that can lead to severe distress and physical injury in companion animals.[173] [174] [175]Studies show that 62% of dogs display signs of distress during fireworks displays.[176] Cats also associate loud noises with danger, and become stressed by fireworks as a result.[177]

Farmed animals are also negatively impacted by fireworks, the sudden loud noises and flashing lights of fireworks trigger extreme fear and stress responses, even at a distance, resulting in dangerous escape behaviours – stampedes, running into fences and equipment, and into dangerous situations such as roads. Animals can ingest fireworks debris resulting in internal injury, or be injured by direct contact with projectile fireworks.[178]

Public Support

The SPCA receives a surge in reports of frightened and missing pets following fireworks events, with many animals suffering panic, injuries, flight responses, and long-term behavioural issues. Some animals never fully recover from fireworks trauma. The

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[171] Phillips, Y. (2023, January 31). *Short-term bang of fireworks has long-term impact on wildlife: study*. Curtin University. https://www.curtin.edu.au/news/media-release/short-term-bang-of-fireworks-has-long-term-impact-on-wildlife-study/

[172] Michel, R. (2025, July 4). Fireworks: An explosion of fear for animals. *The New York Times*. https://www.nytimes.com/2025/07/04/climate/fireworks-animals-pollution.html

[173] FOUR PAWS. (n.d.). *Fireworks are frightening to pets*. https://www.four-paws.org/our-stories/publications-guides/fireworks-are-frightening-to-pets

[174] Smith, J. (2025, September 10). *Nightmare season: Protect your pets from a fireworks fright*. Stuff. https://www.stuff.co.nz/home-property/360469213/nightmare-season-protect-your-pets-fireworks-fright

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[177] Vets Now. (2019, October 11). *How do fireworks affect cats and how do I help my scared cat?* Vets Now. Retrieved from https://www.vets-now.com/pet-care-advice/how-do-fireworks-affect-cats/

[178] RSPCA. (n.d.). *Bang out of order: Fireworks frighten animals*. https://politicalanimal.rspca.org.uk/documents/d/political-animal/rspca-report_-bang-out-of-order-fireworks-frighten-animals-3-1-

SPCA,[179] New Zealand Veterinary Association [180] and Companion Animals New Zealand [181] advocate for a ban on the private sale and use of fireworks in New Zealand.

A petition by NZ retail pet store chain Animates in 2024 was signed by over 90,000 New Zealanders, demonstrating clear public support for fireworks restrictions.[182] This represents a significant mandate from the community which are most aware of the harm which fireworks can or could cause.

Broader Benefits

Adoption of this policy would position Aotearoa as a leader in compassionate and responsible governance, prioritising the well-being of people, animals and the environment and demonstrating that celebration and environmental responsibility are not mutually exclusive. By ending private fireworks use, we would protect our unique ecosystems, reduce animal suffering, and respond to clear public demand for change.

Professional fireworks displays, while more controlled than private use, still cause the same environmental contamination and wildlife disturbance. Modern alternatives like synchronised drone shows offer equally spectacular celebrations without any of these harms.[183]

The policy recognises that when we know better, we must do better. Just as we no longer permit smoking in cars with children, we must evolve our approach to celebrations that cause significant preventable harms. This is a policy whose time has come.

Key Objectives

1. Prohibit private sales of fireworks to individuals across all retail channels.
2. Legislate against private use of fireworks.
3. Phase out professional fireworks displays over a 1-2 year transition period.

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[179] SPCA New Zealand. (n.d.). *Fireworks*. https://www.spca.nz/advocacy/position-statements/article/fireworks
[180] New Zealand Veterinary Association. (n.d.). *Position statement: Fireworks sale and use*. https://nzva.org.nz/positions-advocacy/position-statements/fireworks/
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4. Transition to sustainable celebration alternatives which are proven to not harm animals or the environment.
5. Support development and adoption of new celebration technologies that honour community values while protecting wildlife and the environment.
6. Strengthen enforcement of fireworks regulations with meaningful penalties for violations during the transition period.

October 2025

Artificial Intelligence and Animal Welfare

Introduction

The Animal Justice Party of Aotearoa New Zealand (AJP) recognises that artificial intelligence (AI) is rapidly transforming how millions of animals are managed across farming, aquaculture and introduced species control in Aotearoa New Zealand. While AI technologies offer potential to improve animal welfare through enhanced monitoring and early disease detection, they also risk entrenching harmful practices and creating new forms of harm if deployed without adequate governance systems.

AJP does not endorse the continued expansion of animal agriculture. Any use of AI in these systems must demonstrate responsible development and genuine prioritisation of animal welfare and harm minimisation. We oppose AI technology systems designed purely for economic efficiency that treat animals as units of production rather than as sentient individuals with inherent value.

AJP calls for immediate integration of animal welfare and protection considerations into AI governance frameworks before harmful practices become economically entrenched and impossible to reform. The long-term policy direction of AI must prioritise transition away from animal farming, not the technological optimisation of it.

Context

The Scale of AI Deployment

AI technologies are already deployed across Aotearoa New Zealand's animal management systems at unprecedented scale. Over 400,000 cattle are currently managed using AI-powered virtual fencing systems, whilst millions more animals in dairy, beef, sheep, chicken, aquaculture systems and introduced species control are increasingly likely to be subject to AI-driven management decisions.

AI systems are being rapidly integrated into the management of these animals, making autonomous decisions about their welfare, health and lives.

Current AI applications include:

- Virtual fencing and herding: AI-integrated wearable technology using sounds and vibration to control animal movement, with systems learning and predicting individual behaviour patterns
- Slaughterhouse automation, Computer vision, machine learning and robotics for carcass grading, meat inspection, automated restraint, and cutting, optimising yield and throughput.
- Health monitoring: Computer vision and machine learning analysing gait patterns, body condition and behaviour to assess welfare
- Automated feeding and milking: AI-optimised systems managing nutrition and dairy production
- Aquaculture management: Machine learning for biomass measurement, feeding optimisation and water quality monitoring
- Introduced species control: AI-powered cameras in traps using species recognition, and autonomous drones identifying and poisoning target animals

The Regulatory Gap

The Animal Welfare Act 1999 was enacted before AI technology existed and contains no provisions for AI-driven animal management and welfare. This creates a critical regulatory time lag where technology is reshaping human-animal relationships faster than legislation and regulation can adapt.

Aotearoa New Zealand's AI Strategy (July 2025), positions agriculture as a key adoption sector but contains no animal welfare considerations. The accompanying Responsible AI Guidance for Businesses covers cybersecurity, privacy and intellectual property whilst omitting animal welfare entirely. The Ministry of Business, Innovation and Employment has been explicit that "unlike EU regulatory approaches, our approach is dispersed. The Government doesn't intend to put in place an overarching AI Act. AI risks should be managed in relevant legislation as they arise."(email correspondence Oct 2025).

This dispersed “light touch” approach is already being implemented in other sectors. 2025 changes to the Commerce Act, address AI-facilitated anti-competitive conduct, ensuring companies are liable for AI actions. Additionally, a Members Bill was introduced (2025) to amend the Harmful Digital Communications and Crimes Act 1961 to address AI-generated harms such as deepfakes. These examples confirm that rapid, targeted legislative response is possible.

Animal welfare requires the same urgency. Without explicit action to integrate welfare considerations into relevant existing Acts, AI governance will continue to treat animal welfare as a low-priority externality rather than a core consideration.

Without explicit regulatory requirements, AI systems will inevitably be designed solely for economic efficiency rather than animal welfare and protection. Market forces alone cannot ensure welfare and safety outcomes; only regulation can mandate that AI development prioritises animals' behavioural, physical and mental needs rather than subordinating them to economic and productivity metrics.

Case Study: Virtual Fencing Regulatory Lag

Virtual fencing technology demonstrates the pattern of regulatory lag that affects AI systems deployment. Despite operating commercially since at least 2020 and affecting hundreds of thousands of cattle:

- Circa 2021: The National Animal Welfare Advisory Committee (NAWAC) recommended safeguards for virtual fencing in its Code of Welfare Evaluation Report on Dairy Cattle, stating these "should have more generic application than only virtual fencing and apply to any future technology proposed for animal management"
- Early 2024: A petition called for a parliamentary inquiry into virtual fencing technology
- December 2024: Veterinarians for Animal Welfare Aotearoa announced development of a code of ethical conduct for virtual fencing, demonstrating industry concern whilst government action remained pending
- April 2025: The Petitions Committee recommended inclusion of guidance in the Code of Welfare: Dairy Cattle update

- July 2025: The government noted that virtual fencing presents "an opportunity to review the standards" but provided no timeline for implementation
- Late 2025: NAWAC's work programme plans to provide a revised recommendation, with no certainty about when actual regulatory guidance will be implemented

This five-year lag between commercial deployment and potential regulatory guidance illustrates the systematic failure to apply anticipatory regulation principles to animal welfare contexts, despite on-going advocacy by the Society for the Prevention of Cruelty to Animals (SPCA). Without proactive intervention, each new AI technology will follow this same pattern: commercial deployment, widespread adoption, entrenchment in industry practice, then belated regulatory consideration of animal welfare and safety.

Global Context and Market Pressures

Globally, most AI governance frameworks have overlooked animal welfare. The OECD's AI Principles and most national AI strategies focus exclusively on human-centred concerns such as privacy, bias, transparency, data integrity, accountability and safety. However, a significant breakthrough occurred in July 2025, when the EU's General-Purpose AI Code of Practice explicitly listed "risk to non-human welfare" as a systemic risk, alongside threats to democratic processes, financial stability and environmental harm. This represents the first time a major jurisdiction has formally recognised that AI governance must consider animal welfare, achieved through successful advocacy by animal welfare organisations during the drafting stage.

Beyond the EU, Serbia's AI framework explicitly states AI systems "must be in line with the well-being of humans, animals, and the environment." These examples demonstrate that inclusion of animal welfare in AI governance is both achievable and is increasingly being recognised as necessary.

The AI animal health market is projected to grow from approximately $1.4 billion in 2024 to over $8 billion by 2034, with the farmed animal sector expected to see the fastest growth. This rapid investment is occurring without systematic regulatory oversight of welfare outcomes, creating substantial risk that AI systems will entrench rather than improve current harmful practices.

Welfare Risks of Unregulated AI

- **Intensification of harmful practices**: AI technology makes existing harmful practices more efficient rather than more humane. It integrates best with intensive, cage-based systems that have the worst welfare conditions, enabling higher stocking densities and more intensive confinement, whilst appearing to ensure individualised care.
- **Economic prioritisation**: Data collection prioritises economic metrics over welfare indicators. AI systems optimise measurable parameters (e.g. milk yield, growth rate, feed conversion) whilst potentially missing qualitative welfare aspects such as emotional wellbeing, behavioural freedom and social relationships.
- **Reduced human oversight**: Fewer human caregivers enable larger-scale operations, removing human-animal relationships and reducing opportunities for animals to receive individualised attention and compassionate care.

- **Degraded human-animal relationship**: humans become algorithm supervisors rather than carers risking moral injury and loss of empathy. Sentient beings are viewed as data streams.
- **Technological dependency**: System failures could leave animals without care. Farms become vulnerable to hacking, sabotage and corporate espionage. Adverse weather conditions may impact camera-based systems.
- **Welfare washing**: AI systems create the appearance of individualised care whilst facilitating intensive systems. Companies can claim "precision welfare" or "AI-monitored health" whilst maintaining fundamentally harmful practices.
- **Automated lethal control**: AI-powered introduced species control technologies operate without direct human oversight of individual animal deaths, making life-or-death decisions autonomously. This raises serious ethical questions about delegating such decisions to algorithms designed for efficiency rather than compassion.

Economic Scale and Digital Divide

High AI technology implementation costs will create a digital divide where smaller operations cannot access technologies that larger commercial operations use for both efficiency and welfare monitoring. This risks creating a two-tiered system where animal welfare outcomes depend on economic scale rather than consistent regulatory standards, with larger operations able to demonstrate compliance through AI systems monitoring, whilst smaller farms lack resources for equivalent compliance systems.

The Window for Action

Despite AI technology deployment already underway across Aotearoa New Zealand's animal management systems, the window for proactive policy intervention still remains open. While systems already affect hundreds of thousands of animals, harmful practices have not yet become so economically entrenched that reform is impossible.

The government has demonstrated capacity for rapid legislative response when circumstances require it. In May 2025, Parliament passed the Wildlife (Authorisations) Amendment Bill under urgency to clarify authority for killing protected wildlife during development projects, responding within months to a High Court decision. This swift action demonstrates that regulatory speed depends on political prioritisation rather than legislative capacity.

Connection to Existing AJP Policies

Several existing AJP policies already provide a foundation for addressing AI systems and improving animal welfare:

- Commissioner for Animals: An independent Commissioner would provide necessary impartial oversight to manage inter-agency coordination on AI governance and ensure animal welfare and protection remains central to technological development
- Sentience and Legal Status: AJP's existing advocacy for abolishing the classification of animals as property, extended species coverage and defining sentience clearly in the Animal Welfare Act

1999 directly supports the need for AI systems to recognise animals as sentient individuals rather than productive units
- Worker Rights and Safety: Existing policies on Health and Safety at Work align with the recommendation to include animal welfare in automated system safety assessments
- Transparency and Whistleblowing: Policies protecting those who expose cruelty support the need for accountability in AI-managed systems

However, the unique challenges posed by AI systems require specific additional measures beyond these existing governance frameworks.

Key Objectives

1. Amend the Animal Welfare Act 1999 to explicitly address AI applications affecting animals, including:

- Specific welfare and protection provisions for AI systems in both farming and introduced species control contexts
- Mandatory independent validation of AI welfare monitoring systems before commercial deployment
- Requirements for human oversight alongside AI systems automation, ensuring that critical welfare decisions are not delegated entirely to algorithms
- Mandatory welfare impact assessments for new AI technologies before deployment at commercial scale
- Prohibition of AI systems that conceal, normalise or facilitate harm or cruelty
- Clear accountability frameworks establishing who is responsible when AI management systems decisions cause animal harm or welfare failures

2. Update Codes of Welfare to include AI-specific guidance, beginning with the Code of Welfare: Dairy Cattle to address virtual fencing and AI-driven monitoring systems. All Codes should include:

- Generic safeguards applicable to any future technology proposed for animal management
- Standards for AI-enabled welfare monitoring to ensure systems genuinely improve outcomes rather than simply measure declining welfare more precisely
- Requirements for validated welfare benefits before widespread adoption
- Mandatory human competency and oversight requirements

3. Establish an animal-centred design framework for AI systems affecting animals, requiring that:

- Systems must be explicitly designed for animal welfare, competence and protection, not merely economic efficiency
- Design processes incorporate the Five Domains Model of positive animal welfare (Nutrition, Environment, Health, Behavioural Interactions, Mental State)
- Systems actively enhance animals' choice, control, variety, complexity and competence rather than simply monitoring their decline
- Welfare outcomes are validated independently before and after deployment
- Animals' behavioural, physical and mental needs are prioritised above productivity metrics

- Beneficial AI research and development is supported, including non-lethal, humane alternatives for managing human-wildlife conflict, and technologies that facilitate transition to plan-based food systems.

4. Create an Inter-agency AI-Animal Welfare Working Group chaired by the Commissioner for Animals, with representatives from agencies, including (but not limited to) the Ministry for Primary Industries, Department of Conservation, Environmental Protection Authority, Civil Aviation Authority and Commerce Commission, to:

- Develop consistent guidelines and protection mechanisms across existing legislation and regulation
- Coordinate enforcement protocols and information sharing between agencies
- Apply One Welfare principles integrating animal welfare, human wellbeing and environmental considerations before AI systems are deployed
- Report annually on AI systems developments, regulatory gaps and welfare outcomes
- Monitor emerging AI technologies and assess their welfare implications before widespread deployment

5. Build regulatory capacity to assess and monitor AI technologies by:

- Develop AI literacy programmes for Ministry for Primary Industries inspectors and Department of Conservation staff, enabling them to evaluate AI-based animal management systems
- Create farmer and animal manager education programmes ensuring those who deploy AI can interpret outputs, recognise system failures and maintain appropriate human oversight
- Develop assessment tools and criteria for evaluating AI-based welfare systems
- Provide agencies with ongoing resources to understand rapidly evolving AI technologies and improve governance frameworks

6. Leverage existing legislative frameworks to address AI-animal welfare intersections immediately, without waiting for new legislation, including:

- Privacy Act 2020: Extend data protection to animal-derived biometric data, ensuring commercial interests cannot exploit animal data without welfare safeguards and protection
- Fair Trading Act 1986: Strengthen enforcement against misleading welfare claims, particularly "welfare washing" where AI systems monitoring is marketed as welfare improvement without evidencing genuine benefit to animals
- Consumer Guarantees Act 1993: Ensure AI animal management systems meet fitness-for-purpose standards when welfare outcomes are promised
- Resource Management Act 1991: Include animal welfare and protection in environmental impact assessments for AI systems
- Health and Safety at Work Act 2015: Include animal welfare considerations in automated system safety assessments

- Hazardous Substances and New Organisms (HSNO) Act 1996 and Agricultural Compounds and Veterinary Medicines (ACVM) Act 1997: Require welfare impact assessments for AI systems for all new technological interventions
- Biosecurity Act 1993: Integrate welfare standards into AI-powered introduced species control programmes
- Civil Aviation Act 1990: Mandate welfare protocols for drone-based animal operations, including both monitoring and lethal control applications
- Wildlife Act 1953: Establish 'humane' standards for AI-enabled introduced species control technologies, recognising that automation does not eliminate legal and ethical obligations
- Conservation Act 1987: Ensure the Department of Conservation's AI systems deployment prioritises conservation and welfare outcomes over operational efficiency

7. Establish transparency and accountability requirements for AI systems affecting animals:

- Mandatory public reporting of AI deployment scale, including the number of animals affected and the types of systems used
- Accessible data on welfare outcomes, system failures and interventions
- Clear pathways for reporting, and addressing, welfare concerns related to AI systems
- Protection for whistleblowers who expose AI systems-related welfare failures
- Public registers of validated AI welfare management systems
- Consolidated national statistics on introduced species control methods, kill numbers and welfare outcomes to enable comprehensive assessment of both traditional and AI-enabled systems

8. Prohibit AI applications that:

- Enable increased stocking densities or more intensive confinement
- Reduce human-animal contact below minimum welfare standards
- Make autonomous lethal decisions without human oversight
- Prioritise economic optimisation at the expense of animal welfare and protection
- Conceal or normalise practices that would otherwise be recognised as harmful or cruel

9. Ensure AI governance frameworks address sentience comprehensively:

- Expand explicit species coverage in animal welfare legislation to reflect current scientific understanding of sentience, including cephalopods, decapods, fishes and other invertebrates (as outlined in existing AJP policy on animal sentience and legal status)
- Regulate AI systems affecting aquaculture and commercial fishing with the same rigour as terrestrial animal systems
- Require that AI design processes acknowledge and respond to positive species-specific behavioural and cognitive needs

Interim Measures

While comprehensive legislative amendments are developed and implemented, AJP supports immediate actions to reduce harm:

10. Issue urgent guidance under existing legislation to all research facilities, farms and conservation operations using AI systems, requiring:

- Immediate risk and animal impact assessments of current AI deployments
- Enhanced human oversight protocols
- Mandatory reporting of welfare failures related to AI systems
- Suspension of AI systems that cannot demonstrate welfare benefits

11. Implement emergency protocols for deployed AI systems:

- Mandatory backup systems ensuring animal care safely continues during technological failures
- Clear escalation and resolution procedures when AI systems indicate welfare problems
- Regular audits of AI systems decision-making to identify and rectify harmful patterns
- Immediate intervention and resolution requirements when AI systems recommend actions contrary to animal welfare

12. Fast-track regulatory capacity building by establishing an AI literacy programme for Ministry for Primary Industries inspectors and Department of Conservation staff, a rapid response team with expertise in both AI technology and animal welfare and interim assessment tools for currently deployed AI systems.

13.. Prioritise virtual fencing regulation as a test case for broader AI governance:

- Implement NAWAC's recommended safeguards immediately through the Code of Welfare: Dairy Cattle (on the assumption they are reasonable in relation to the code of ethical conduct developed by the Veterinarians for Animal Welfare Aotearoa)
- Require independent welfare validation of existing virtual fencing systems
- Establish clear standards for appropriate use, system maintenance and animal conditioning
- Prohibit use near milking sheds and in situations where animals cannot retreat from stimuli

14. Conduct comprehensive AI systems deployment mapping across all animal management sectors to identify the current scale and scope of AI systems use, assess the welfare risks, prioritise regulatory intervention and establish transparent baseline data for measuring regulatory effectiveness.

15. Establish interim consultation processes ensuring:

- Animal welfare organisations are consulted on AI technology development and deployment
- Welfare and protection considerations are integrated into industry AI systems adoption decisions
- Public input is sought and integrated for AI technologies affecting animals
- Affected communities, including farmers and conservation practitioners, contribute to ongoing regulatory development

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